

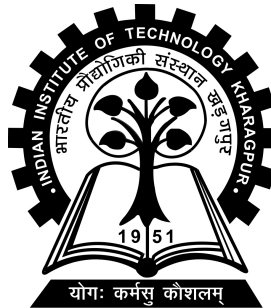
Computer Vision Framework for Defect Detection and Microstructure Analysis in Materials

Project-II (MT47001) report submitted to
Indian Institute of Technology Kharagpur
in partial fulfilment for the award of the degree of
Bachelor of Technology
in
Metallurgical and Materials Engineering

by

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Spring Semester, 2025-26

May 01, 2026

DECLARATION

I certify that

- (a) The work contained in this report has been done by us under the guidance of our supervisor.
- (b) The work has not been submitted to any other Institute for any degree or diploma.
- (c) We have conformed to the norms and guidelines given in the Ethical Code of Conduct of the Institute.
- (d) Whenever we have used materials (data, theoretical analysis, figures, and text) from other sources, we have given due credit to them by citing them in the text of the thesis and giving their details in the references. Further, we have taken permission from the copyright owners of the sources, whenever necessary.

Date: May 01, 2026

Place: Kharagpur

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CERTIFICATE

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Abstract

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This thesis presents a unified computer-vision framework for defect detection and microstructure analysis across multiple materials-engineering applications, including non-metallic inclusion analysis in steel, semiconductor wafer-map defect recognition, and semantic segmentation of multi-phase steel microstructures.

The first part develops an automated pipeline for steel inclusion analysis that combines deep-learning-based segmentation, morphology-aware multi-label classification, and quantitative area-fraction estimation from metallographic images. Comparative evaluation across U-Net, U-Net++, Attention U-Net, ENet, and Mask R-CNN shows that Mask R-CNN provides the strongest segmentation performance, while a ResNet50-based classifier enables effective inclusion-type prediction under

limited-data conditions. The framework further converts predictions into physically meaningful measurements through scale-bar calibration and per-instance area computation.

The second part addresses semiconductor wafer-map defect analysis as a spatial-pattern recognition problem relevant to yield monitoring and process diagnosis. It studies wafer-map defect detection and mixed-type defect pattern recognition using the MixedWM38 setting, where multiple defect primitives may coexist on a single wafer. In this context, deformable convolutional networks are used to better capture non-rigid and overlapping defect structures than standard convolutional approaches.

The third part focuses on semantic segmentation of multi-phase steel microstructures. Using a U-Net architecture with an EfficientNet-B4 encoder, combined loss design, and domain-specific augmentation, the framework segments metallurgical phases and defects from limited annotated data, demonstrating the feasibility of automated microstructure characterization for quality-control applications.

Overall, the thesis shows that carefully designed deep-learning pipelines can provide scalable and interpretable support for inspection, classification, segmentation, and quantitative analysis in modern materials and manufacturing systems.

Keywords: computer vision, defect detection, microstructure analysis, steel, non-metallic inclusions, semiconductor wafer maps, semantic segmentation, deformable convolution, U-Net, Mask R-CNN.

Acknowledgements

We sincerely thanks our project guide supervisor, Professor Sumantra Mandal, for his invaluable insights and constructive feedback which made this project a successful endeavour. We also thank Mr. Roshan Jha, Research Scholar, for his guidance throughout the project. Furthermore, we also thank the Department of Metallurgical and Materials Engineering for granting us an opportunity and resources for pursuing this project. We finally extend our gratitude to our family and friends for their support.

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Abbreviations

AF	Area Fraction
AI	Artificial Intelligence
ASTM	American Society for Testing and Materials
BCE	Binary Cross-Entropy
BN	Batch Normalization
CNN	Convolutional Neural Network
COCO	Common Objects in Context
CSV	Comma-Separated Values
CUDA	Compute Unified Device Architecture
DCN	Deformable Convolutional Network
DPR	Defect Pattern Recognition
EDS	Energy Dispersive Spectroscopy
F1	F1-score
FPN	Feature Pyramid Network
GAN	Generative Adversarial Network
GPU	Graphics Processing Unit
HL	Hamming Loss
IC	Integrated Circuit
IoU	Intersection over Union
JSON	JavaScript Object Notation
MixedWM38	Mixed-type Wafer Map dataset with 38 semantic pattern classes
mIoU	Mean Intersection over Union
OCR	Optical Character Recognition
OOM	Out of Memory
PA	Pixel Accuracy
PNG	Portable Network Graphics

ReLU	Rectified Linear Unit
RLE	Run-Length Encoding
RPN	Region Proposal Network
RoI	Region of Interest
SDK	Software Development Kit
SEM	Scanning Electron Microscopy
SEM-EDS	Scanning Electron Microscopy–Energy Dispersive Spectroscopy
SGD	Stochastic Gradient Descent
ViT	Vision Transformer
VRAM	Video Random Access Memory
WM	Wafer Map

Symbols

Al_2O_3	Aluminum Oxide (Alumina)	—
MnS	Manganese Sulfide	—
SiO_2	Silicon Dioxide (Silica)	—
σ	Stress Tensor	—
ε	Strain Tensor	—
x	Input feature map or wafer-map tensor	—
y	Output feature map after convolution	—
p_0	Target output location on the feature map	pixel index
p_n	Standard kernel sampling location	pixel index
Δp_n	Learnable two-dimensional spatial offset	pixel index
R	Regular convolution sampling grid	set of coordinates
$G(q, p)$	Bilinear interpolation kernel weight	—
$g(a, b)$	One-dimensional linear interpolation term	—
C	Circularity	dimensionless
AR	Aspect ratio	dimensionless
AF_t	Area fraction of inclusion type t	percent
$A_{\text{phys}, t}$	Physical area of inclusion type t	μm^2
P	Predicted probability map or precision, depending on context	—
G	Ground-truth mask	—
TP	True positives	count
TN	True negatives	count
FP	False positives	count
FN	False negatives	count
α	Attention coefficient / gate weight	—
$\hat{z}$	Predicted multi-label output vector	probability
z	Ground-truth multi-label code	binary vector

Chapter 1

Introduction, Background, and Pipeline Design

1.0.1 Non-Metallic Inclusions in Steel

Non-metallic inclusions (NMIs) are chemical compounds of metallic elements (Fe, Mn, Al, Si, Ca) with non-metals (O, S, C, N) that form separate phases embedded in the steel matrix. They arise during deoxidation, desulfurisation, reoxidation, or contamination from refractories and slag during steelmaking and casting. Because they disrupt the homogeneity of the steel matrix, inclusions act as stress concentration sites under mechanical loading, and their impact on steel properties is governed strongly by their type, size, morphology, spatial distribution, and volume fraction.

The consequences of excessive inclusion content are well-documented: fatigue crack initiation at hard oxide particles in high-cycle applications, anisotropic ductility due to elongated sulfide stringers, nozzle clogging from alumina clusters during continuous casting, and surface defects during polishing or plating of precision parts.

1.0.2 ASTM E45 Classification of Inclusions

The ASTM E45 standard defines four morphological types of inclusions that form the basis of both the classification labels and the morphology-score mapping used

in this work.

- Type A (Sulfide): Manganese sulfide (MnS) inclusions that are highly malleable, deforming plastically during hot working to produce long, smooth, gray stringers with rounded ends.
- Type B (Alumina): Aluminum oxide (Al_2O_3) inclusions that are brittle and hard, fracturing into chains of small, dark, angular particles during hot working.
- Type C (Silicate): Silicate (SiO_2 -based) inclusions that are deformable but less so than sulfides, producing elongated stringers with sharp, pointed ends.
- Type D (Globular Oxide): Calcium aluminate and other non-Type-B oxides that remain globular and randomly distributed, appearing as circular dark particles.

1.0.3 Project Context: BTP-1 vs. BTP-2

BTP-1 (Autumn Semester 2025-26) established the foundational pipeline through a comparative study of five segmentation architectures (U-Net, U-Net++, Attention U-Net, ENet, and Mask R-CNN) on an annotated steel microstructure dataset, followed by ResNet50-based multi-label classification. The results demonstrated that Mask R-CNN, by virtue of its instance-level formulation and ResNet-50 FPN backbone, significantly outperformed the semantic segmentation models. The classification stage achieved a macro F1 of 0.7018 despite the small dataset.

BTP-2 (Spring Semester 2025-26) builds directly on this foundation and extends it in three directions: (1) systematic fixes and enhancements to the BTP-1 code, (2) a complete new third stage for quantitative area fraction estimation, and (3) unification of all three stages into a single, reproducible Jupyter notebook pipeline that can process entire folders of original micrographs in batch mode.

1.0.4 Motivation for Quantitative Area Fraction

The BTP-1 pipeline addressed the qualitative question: which inclusions are present and where? BTP-2 addresses the quantitative question demanded by industrial standards, namely how much area do inclusions of each type occupy. ASTM E1245 specifies area fraction as the primary metric for automated inclusion rating. Without a calibrated physical measurement, the segmentation and classification outputs have limited actionability for process control. BTP-2 closes this gap by recovering the calibration constant from the scale bar embedded in every optical micrograph and converting pixel counts to physical areas in μm^2 .

1.1 BTP-2 Contributions: New and Modified Components

Table 1 summarises every component that changed or was newly introduced in BTP-2, with the rationale for each change. The items marked "NEW" represent the primary technical contributions of this semester; the remaining items are engineering corrections that were necessary to make the BTP-1 models train correctly.

TABLE 1.1: BTP-1 vs. BTP-2 component comparison.

Component BTP-1		BTP-2	Rationale
Loss function	Pure BCE	$0.5 \times \text{BCE} + 0.5 \times \text{Dice}$	Dice loss directly optimises overlap and corrects the majority-class bias that BCE alone produces on sparse inclusion images.

Continued on next page

TABLE 1.1: BTP-1 vs. BTP-2 component comparison (continued).

Component BTP-1		BTP-2	Rationale
ENet bottleneck stride	stride=1 in main conv when down-sample=True	stride=2 in c2 when downsam-ple=True	Without this, the main path ($H \times W$) and shortcut ($H/2 \times W/2$) had incompatible shapes for residual addition, silently preventing ENet training.
ENet activations	ReLU	PReLU (learnable slope, per original paper)	PReLU allows a learned non-zero negative response, preserving gradient flow for sparse inclusion signals.
ENet shortcut branch	Single Conv2d	Conv2d + BatchNorm	Adding BatchNorm to the shortcut stabilises gradient flow and prevents scale mismatch on residual summation.
Coco Mask Dataset	Minimal dict (boxes, labels, masks)	Full dict including iscrowd and area	Newer torchvision Mask R-CNN API requires all fields; omitting them caused silent failures.
LR schedule	Fixed learning rate	Adam + ReduceLROnPlateau (patience=5, factor=0.5)	Automatic LR decay on validation plateau prevents overshooting and yields better final checkpoints.

Continued on next page

TABLE 1.1: BTP-1 vs. BTP-2 component comparison (continued).

Component	BTP-1	BTP-2	Rationale
Checkpoint logic	Always overwrites saved model	SKIP_IF_EXISTS flag	Allows safe re-runs without accidentally wiping trained weights when training models sequentially.
models.py generation	inspect .getsource()	Hardcoded string literal	inspect.getsource() fails on Windows/Python 3.11 for Jupyter notebook classes.
Classification thresholds	Fixed 0.50 for all classes	Per-class: [0.35, 0.40, 0.40, 0.50]	Sulfide and Silicate inclusions were systematically under-predicted at 0.50; per-class tuning improved minority class recall.
Stage 3: Scale-bar OCR	Not present	NEW: EasyOCR + morphological Hough transform -; px_per_um	Recovers physical calibration constant automatically from every micrograph without manual input.
Stage 3: Morphology scoring	Not present	NEW: circularity + aspect ratio per instance -; ASTM E45 score vector	Provides per-instance shape information that the image-level classifier cannot capture.

Continued on next page

TABLE 1.1: BTP-1 vs. BTP-2 component comparison (continued).

Component BTP-1		BTP-2	Rationale
Stage 3: Type assignment	Not present	NEW: 0.6 x classifier + 0.4 x morphology weighted vote	Combining global classifier confidence with local shape descriptors gives more accurate per-instance labels.
Stage 3: Area fraction	Not present	NEW: AF = pixel area / total pixels x 100%; physical area in μm^2	Converts qualitative detection output to ASTM E1245-compliant quantitative area measurements.
Instance area filter	None	NEW: min_area = 350 px in original resolution	Removes polishing scratches and detector noise below $\sim 22 \mu\text{m}^2$, smaller than any real ASTM E45 inclusion.
CUDA OOM recovery	Crash on large images	NEW: auto-retry at max_size=640 on RuntimeError(out of memory)	Ensures batch pipeline completes on GPUs with limited VRAM (e.g., RTX 3050 with 4 GB).
Batch output format	None	NEW: per-image overlay PNG + .txt report + batch CSV	Enables systematic analysis of entire micrograph datasets for industrial quality control workflows.

1.2 Theoretical Background

This section provides the theoretical foundations for the models and methods used in this work. Readers familiar with BTP-1 may skip Sections 3.1 through 3.3, which cover architectures already evaluated in the first semester. Section 3.4 (the BCE+Dice combined loss) and the BTP-2-specific subsections on ENet corrections and Mask R-CNN inference are new to this report.

1.2.1 Deep Learning Foundations (Brief Review)

The following standard operations and concepts are used throughout the pipeline. They are listed here with their mathematical definitions for completeness and for ease of reference when converting this report to the final LaTeX paper.

Convolution operation at position (i, j) for kernel W and feature map X :

$$Y(i, j) = \sum_m \sum_n X(i - m, j - n) W(m, n) \quad (1)$$

Batch normalisation, where μ and σ^2 are batch statistics, and γ and β are learnable parameters:

$$\hat{x} = \frac{x - \mu}{\sqrt{\sigma^2 + \varepsilon}}, \quad y = \gamma \hat{x} + \beta \quad (2)$$

Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU) and Parametric ReLU (PReLU) with learnable slope a :

$$\text{ReLU}(x) = \max(0, x) \quad (3)$$

$$\text{PReLU}(x) = \begin{cases} x, & x \geq 0, \\ ax, & x < 0 \end{cases} \quad (4)$$

Sigmoid activation used in binary classification heads:

$$\sigma(x) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-x}} \quad (5)$$

Binary cross-entropy loss over N samples:

$$L_{\text{BCE}} = -\frac{1}{N} \sum_i [y_i \log(\hat{y}_i) + (1 - y_i) \log(1 - \hat{y}_i)] \quad (6)$$

Pooling layers progressively downsample feature maps, increasing receptive field size. Skip connections (residual connections) allow gradients to bypass non-linear blocks, enabling training of very deep networks. Transfer learning from ImageNet pre-training is critical here because only 107 original micrographs were available for classification training, far too few to train from scratch without overfitting.

1.2.2 Segmentation Architectures

BTP-1 evaluated five segmentation architectures. U-Net [1], U-Net++ [2], and Attention U-Net [3] are encoder-decoder models operating on 256x256 input patches with pixel-level binary output. Their architectures are described in the BTP-1 report and are not reproduced here in full. The two architectures most relevant to BTP-2 are ENet (because of the bug fix introduced this semester) and Mask R-CNN (because it is the selected backbone for the full pipeline).

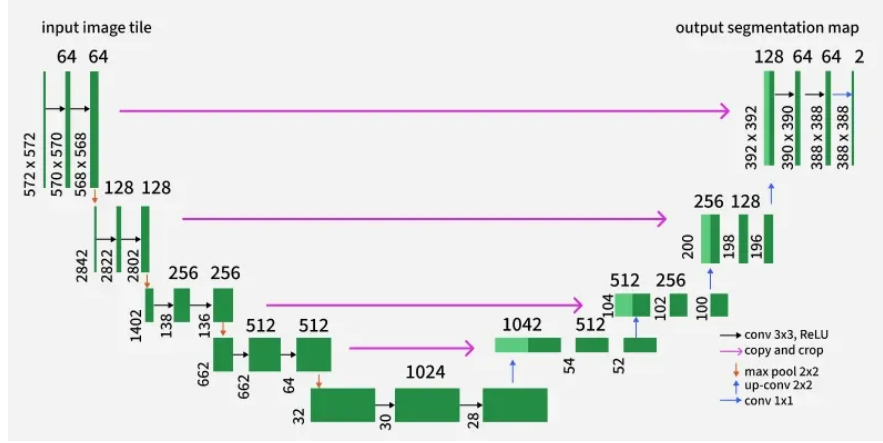


FIGURE 1.1: U-Net encoder-decoder architecture with skip connections. Four max-pooling levels double the channel count (64 to 512) in the encoder; transposed convolutions and skip-connection recover spatial detail in the decoder.

1.2.2.1 U-Net++ Dense Skip Connections

U-Net++ [2] introduces dense nested skip connections that fill the semantic gap between encoder and decoder features. Each intermediate node $X^{i,j}$ aggregates all previous nodes in the same dense block:

$$X^{i,j} = H^{i,j}([X^{i,k} \text{ for } k < j], \text{Up}(X^{i+1,j-1})) \quad (7)$$

This ensemble of intermediate paths allows the network to reuse low-level features at multiple decoder depths, which is beneficial for objects of varying sizes since inclusions range from sub-pixel specks to long stringers spanning hundreds of pixels.

1.2.2.2 Attention U-Net

Attention U-Net [3] augments standard skip connections with soft attention gates. The gate combines the decoder gating signal g and the encoder skip signal x_l through learned projections:

$$q_{\text{att}} = W_g * g + W_x * x_l \quad (8)$$

$$\alpha = \sigma(W_\psi * \text{ReLU}(q_{\text{att}})) \quad (9)$$

$$\hat{x}_l = \alpha * x_l \quad (10)$$

This causes the gate to suppress responses in irrelevant background regions and focus on inclusion-bearing areas without additional supervision.

1.2.2.3 ENet and the BTP-2 Bug Fix

ENet [4] is designed for real-time semantic segmentation with minimal parameters. Its key design choices are: (1) an early aggressive downsampling stage (InitialBlock: stride-2 conv concatenated with MaxPool, giving 16x downsampling in only two operations), (2) bottleneck modules with 1x1 channel compression followed by either a regular 3x3 convolution, dilated convolution, or asymmetric factored convolution (1x5 then 5x1), and (3) a sparse decoder that holds less than 10% of the total parameters.

The ENet bottleneck residual computation is:

$$h = \text{PReLU}(\text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{1 \times 1}(x))) \quad (11)$$

$$m = \text{PReLU}(\text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{f \times f, s}(h))) \quad (12)$$

$$e = \text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{1 \times 1}(m)) \quad (13)$$

$$y = \text{PReLU}(e + \text{shortcut}(x)) \quad (14)$$

where $s = 2$ and $f = 2$ when downsampling. The critical BTP-2 correction: in BTP-1, the middle convolution (Equation 12) incorrectly used stride $s = 1$ even when `downsample=True`. This caused the main path to produce feature maps of shape $H \times W$ while the shortcut produced $H/2 \times W/2$, making the residual addition in Equation 14 impossible. BTP-2 sets stride to $s = 2$ and uses a 2×2 kernel, matching the shortcut spatial dimensions exactly. Without this fix, ENet training silently failed at the first forward pass through a downsampling bottleneck.

1.2.2.4 Mask R-CNN

Mask R-CNN [5] is a two-stage instance segmentation framework and is the model selected for the BTP-2 pipeline. Stage 1 is the Region Proposal Network (RPN), a small CNN that slides over the feature pyramid and proposes candidate object regions at multiple scales and aspect ratios, with non-maximum suppression filtering overlapping proposals. Stage 2 uses RoIAlign, a differentiable sub-pixel-accurate feature extraction operation, to produce fixed-size feature maps from each proposal, then runs three parallel heads predicting class scores (Softmax), bounding box refinement offsets (smooth L1), and a binary 28×28 pixel mask (sigmoid, independent per class).

The multi-task loss is:

$$L = L_{\text{rpn.cls}} + L_{\text{rpn.box}} + L_{\text{cls}} + L_{\text{box}} + L_{\text{mask}} \quad (15)$$

where the RPN objectness loss is:

$$L_{\text{rpn.cls}} = \text{BCE}(p_i, p_i^*) \quad (16)$$

the box regression loss uses the smooth L1 function:

$$L_{\text{box}} = \sum_i \text{smooth_L1}(t_i - t_i^*) \quad (17)$$

$$\text{smooth_L1}(x) = \begin{cases} 0.5x^2, & |x| < 1 \\ |x| - 0.5, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \quad (18)$$

and the mask loss is averaged over only the ground-truth class branch:

$$L_{\text{mask}} = -\frac{1}{m^2} \sum_{i,j} [y_{ij} \log(\hat{y}_{ij}) + (1 - y_{ij}) \log(1 - \hat{y}_{ij})] \quad (20)$$

The mask loss decoupled from classification means the network learns to segment any region correctly without interference from the class label, which is particularly beneficial for the fine morphological boundaries of inclusion types.

The ResNet-50 FPN [6, 10] backbone computes feature maps at five resolutions (P2 through P6), each with 256 channels. This pyramid allows RPN anchors at different scales, making Mask R-CNN equally effective for large stringers and tiny globular particles.

1.2.3 ResNet50 Multi-Label Classifier (Brief Review)

ResNet50 [6] consists of 16 bottleneck residual blocks in 4 stages, producing a 2048-dimensional feature vector after global average pooling. Each bottleneck block computes:

$$H(x) = F(x) + x \quad (21)$$

$$F(x) = W_3 * \text{ReLU}(\text{BN}(W_2 * \text{ReLU}(\text{BN}(W_1 * x)))) \quad (22)$$

where F represents the 1x1 to 3x3 to 1x1 convolution sequence. In our classifier (MultiLabelClassifier), the ResNet50 backbone pre-trained on ImageNet is used as a frozen feature extractor, and a custom three-layer head is fine-tuned: Flatten, Dropout(0.5), Linear(2048 to 512), ReLU, Dropout(0.3), Linear(512 to 128), ReLU,

Linear(128 to 4). The final layer outputs raw logits, and BCEWithLogitsLoss applies the sigmoid internally for numerical stability. The multi-label formulation treats each of the four ASTM E45 types as an independent binary prediction, allowing an image to exhibit multiple inclusion types simultaneously:

$$L_{\text{multilabel}} = - \sum_c [y_c \log(\sigma(z_c)) + (1 - y_c) \log(1 - \sigma(z_c))] \quad (23)$$

1.2.4 BCE+Dice Combined Loss Function (BTP-2 Upgrade)

Binary cross-entropy (Equation 6) penalises each pixel independently without accounting for the overall overlap between prediction and ground truth. For highly imbalanced segmentation tasks where background pixels vastly outnumber inclusion pixels, BCE training tends to produce masks that predict background everywhere, achieving high pixel accuracy but near-zero Dice coefficient. The Dice loss directly maximises the overlap between the predicted probability map P and the binary ground truth G :

$$L_{\text{Dice}} = 1 - \frac{2|P \cap G| + \epsilon}{|P| + |G| + \epsilon} \quad (24)$$

The combined loss used in BTP-2 for all U-Net-family models is:

$$L = 0.5L_{\text{BCE}} + 0.5L_{\text{Dice}} \quad (25)$$

This balances pixel-level calibration (BCE) with region-level overlap (Dice), making it particularly well-suited for inclusion segmentation where inclusions are rare but critical to detect correctly.

1.3 Dataset and Data Pipeline

1.3.1 Segmentation Dataset

The segmentation dataset was sourced from 40 to 50 raw steel optical micrographs of polished steel samples. Manual pixel-level polygon annotation of all visible inclusions was performed on the Roboflow platform and stored in COCO Segmentation format, providing per-instance polygon masks and bounding boxes that are directly consumable by Mask R-CNN training API.

Aggressive data augmentation expanded the dataset approximately 4x: 90/180/arbitrary rotations, horizontal and vertical flips, and shear transformations. The final dataset contains approximately 170 images split across train, validation, and test sets. For U-Net-family models, a `coco_to_masks()` conversion function rasterises each polygon annotation into a binary PNG mask (white for inclusion, black for background). For Mask R-CNN, the COCO JSON is consumed directly by a custom `CocoMaskDataset` class derived from `torchvision.datasets.CocoDetection`.

1.3.2 Classification Dataset

The classification dataset consists of 107 original optical micrographs of polished steel samples captured from five to six different steel pieces. Each image was labeled with a binary multi-label vector (Sulfide / Alumina / Silicate / Globular Oxide can each be 0 or 1 independently), stored in Roboflow’s multiclass CSV format. Augmentation expanded the dataset to approximately 600 images for training.

Training-time augmentation applied to the classification dataset included random horizontal flip, vertical flip, 25 degree rotation, and ColorJitter (brightness, contrast, saturation). Inference uses centre-crop-resize only. All images were normalised to ImageNet mean and standard deviation ($[0.485, 0.456, 0.406]$ / $[0.229, 0.224, 0.225]$).

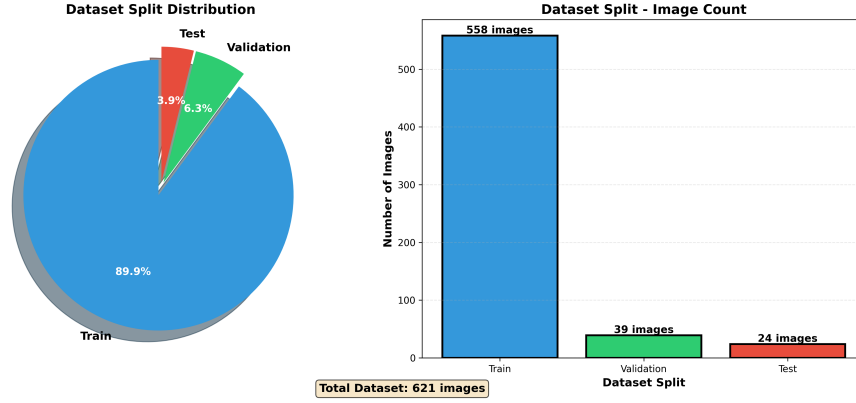


FIGURE 1.2: Class distribution across train, validation, and test splits for the classification dataset. Globular Oxide inclusions are the most frequent class; Alumina is the least represented.

1.3.3 Original Micrographs for Area Fraction Pipeline

The third stage operates on full-resolution original micrographs (3132×2325 pixels) as captured by the optical metallographic microscope. These images contain a scale bar in the bottom-right corner annotated with the physical length (e.g., 50 μm , 100 μm). The pipeline crops the bottom-right 20% of the image to isolate the scale-bar region, then applies OCR and morphological processing to extract the calibration constant.

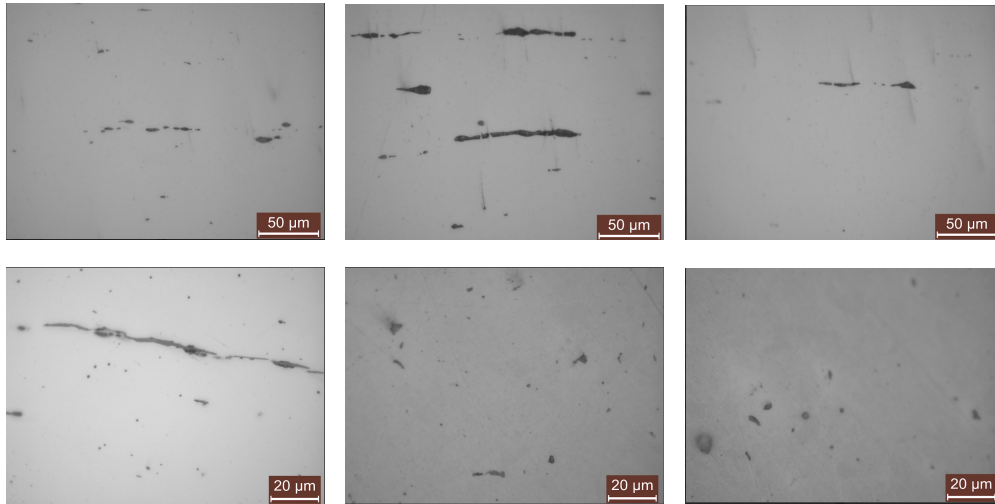


FIGURE 1.3: Representative polished steel sample micrographs from the six steel pieces captured during sample preparation. Variations in magnification and illumination are visible across samples.

1.4 The BTP-2 Three-Stage Pipeline

1.4.1 Pipeline Overview

Given an original steel micrograph, the BTP-2 pipeline runs the following stages in sequence:

- Scale-bar detection: EasyOCR reads the numeric value and unit from the bottom-right region of interest; morphological filtering and a Hough transform measure the bar’s pixel length, yielding the calibration constant `px_per_um`.
- Instance segmentation: Mask R-CNN predicts bounding boxes, confidence scores, and binary pixel masks for all candidate inclusions. The image is resized to at most 1024 px on the longest side to remain within 4 GB VRAM; masks are then upsampled back to the original resolution for accurate area computation.
- Instance filtering: Detections with confidence below 0.65 or pixel area below 350 px in the original image are discarded to remove polishing scratches and detector noise.
- Image-level classification: ResNet50 runs on the full image (resized to 312x312) and outputs a four-element probability vector for the four ASTM E45 types.
- Per-instance type assignment: For each surviving instance, a morphology score vector is computed from circularity and aspect ratio, then combined with the classifier probability vector using weights 0.4 (morphology) and 0.6 (classifier). The type with the highest weighted score is assigned.
- Area fraction computation: For each type, the area fraction and physical area are computed (see Section 5.5).
- Output generation: Annotated overlay PNG with colour-coded inclusions and centroid labels showing type, confidence, and area in μm^2 ; per-image .txt report; and a row in the batch CSV.

1.4.2 Stage 1: Scale-Bar Detection

The `detect_scale_bar()` function crops the bottom-right 20% of the image (approximately 626×465 px for a 3132×2325 micrograph), which is large enough to contain the scale annotation while small enough to exclude most of the microstructure.

EasyOCR is run on this region of interest with an allowlist restricted to digits, units (μm , nm, mm), and spaces. This allowlist dramatically reduces false positives from microstructure features that resemble characters in greyscale imaging. The OCR result is matched against a regular expression for patterns such as "50 μm " or "100 nm". If OCR parsing succeeds, the numeric value and unit are recorded.

The pixel length of the scale bar itself is determined via morphological horizontal opening with a structuring element of width approximately `image_width / 20`, which isolates horizontal line segments, followed by a Hough Line Transform to find the longest line in the region. The calibration constant is then:

$$\text{px_per_}\mu\text{m} = \frac{\text{bar_pixels}}{\text{scale_value}} \quad (26)$$

adjusted for unit (nm divided by 1000, mm multiplied by 1000). If scale bar detection fails, the pipeline continues with `px_per_μm` set to `None` and reports area fractions in pixel units only, preventing the failure from blocking the entire batch.

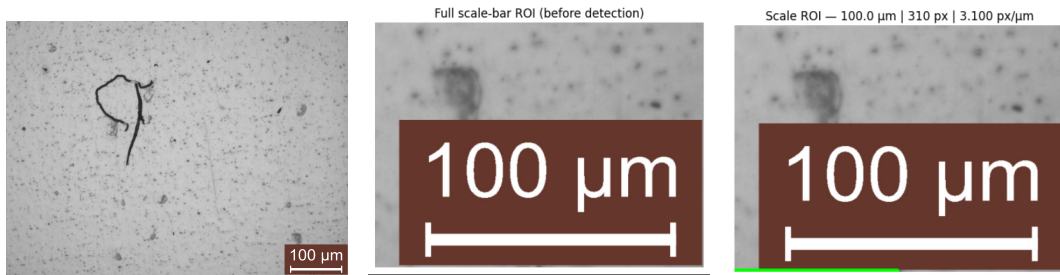


FIGURE 1.4: Scale-bar detection pipeline for a representative micrograph. From left: (a) original full-resolution image, (b) cropped bottom-right ROI, (c) morphologically filtered image with detected scale bar highlighted, and EasyOCR text output with parsed scale value and unit.

1.4.3 Stage 2: Instance Segmentation (Mask R-CNN)

The trained Mask R-CNN model is loaded from the saved checkpoint. Before inference, the image is resized so that its longest dimension equals `SEG_MAX_SIZE = 1024` px, reducing GPU memory from more than 8 GB to approximately 0.8 GB for a 3132×2325 input.

After inference, every predicted mask is upsampled back to the original resolution using nearest-neighbour interpolation to preserve binary boundaries. Instances with confidence score below 0.65 or pixel area in the original image below 350 px are discarded. Each surviving instance contributes its mask, bounding box, confidence, and pixel area to the downstream stages.

The minimum area threshold of 350 px corresponds to approximately $22 \mu\text{m}^2$ at 3.88 px/ μm (a 50 μm scale bar spanning 194 px), which is below the smallest clinically significant ASTM E45 Type D inclusion ($\sim 50 \mu\text{m}^2$) but above typical polishing scratches and OCR artifacts.

1.4.4 Stage 3: Per-Instance Type Assignment

1.4.4.1 Morphology Descriptors

For each Mask R-CNN instance, OpenCV's `findContours()` extracts the outer boundary. Two shape descriptors are computed:

Circularity, where A is the contour area and P is the perimeter:

$$C = \frac{4\pi A}{P^2} \quad (27)$$

A perfect circle gives $C = 1.0$ and long thin stringers approach $C = 0$. Circularity is clipped to $[0, 1]$.

Aspect ratio, computed from the minimum bounding rectangle via `cv2.minAreaRect()`:

$$AR = \frac{\text{major_axis}}{\text{minor_axis}} \quad (28)$$

A sphere gives $AR = 1.0$ and a long stringer gives $AR \gg 1$.

1.4.4.2 ASTM E45-Based Morphology Score Mapping

The shape descriptors are mapped to a four-element score vector using ASTM E45 morphological criteria:

- Globular Oxide (D): $C > 0.55$ and $AR < 2.5$ gives score = $[0.05, 0.10, 0.05, 0.80]$
- Sulfide (A): $AR > 4.0$ and $C < 0.30$ gives score = $[0.80, 0.05, 0.10, 0.05]$
- Silicate (C): $AR > 3.0$ and $C < 0.45$ gives score = $[0.10, 0.05, 0.75, 0.10]$
- Alumina (B): default for angular, moderately elongated clusters gives score = $[0.05, 0.70, 0.15, 0.10]$

1.4.4.3 Combined Weighted Score

The per-instance type is determined by combining the image-level classifier probability vector p_{cls} with the morphology score vector s_{morph} :

$$s_{\text{combined}} = 0.6 p_{\text{cls}} + 0.4 s_{\text{morph}} \quad (29)$$

$$\text{type} = \text{argmax}(s_{\text{combined}}) \quad (30)$$

The 0.6/0.4 weighting favours the classifier, which sees global context and was trained on expert-labeled data, while allowing morphology-based correction for geometrically clear cases such as a perfectly round particle that the classifier may have assigned the wrong label to. This dual-source approach was chosen specifically because the image-level classifier may be dominated by the most visually prominent

inclusion type in an image, incorrectly assigning the same type to a different-shaped minority inclusion.

1.4.5 Area Fraction and Physical Area Computation

For each assigned inclusion type t , the area fraction in percent and the physical area are computed as:

$$AF_t(\%) = \left(\frac{\sum_i \text{pixel_area}_i^t}{H \times W} \right) \times 100 \quad (31)$$

$$A_{\text{phys},t} (\mu\text{m}^2) = \frac{\sum_i \text{pixel_area}_i^t}{(\text{px_per_um})^2} \quad (32)$$

where $H \times W$ is the total image resolution. Equation 32 is valid only if scale bar detection succeeded. The total area fraction $\text{AF_total} = \sum_t \text{AF}_t$ represents a summary cleanliness measure analogous to the ASTM E1245 total inclusion content.

These values are written to: (1) a human-readable per-image text report, (2) the annotated overlay image with per-instance inline labels at mask centroids, and (3) a batch CSV file with one row per image. The CSV columns include filename, scale_value, unit, `px_per_um`, `total_af_pct`, `num_instances`, classifier probabilities for all four types, and per-type count, AF, and μm^2 for each ASTM E45 class.

Chapter 2

Training Configuration, Results, and Discussion

2.0.1 Segmentation Model Training

TABLE 2.1: Segmentation training hyperparameters.

Parameter	U-Net / U-Net++ / Att. U-Net / ENet	Mask R-CNN
Epochs	20	10
Optimizer	Adam (lr = 1e-4)	SGD (lr = 0.005, momentum = 0.9, weight decay = 5e-4)
LR Schedule	ReduceLROnPlateau (patience=5, factor=0.5)	StepLR (step=5, gamma=0.1)
Loss Function	0.5 x BCE + 0.5 x Dice (BTP-2 upgrade)	Multi-task: L _{rpn} + L _{cls} + L _{box} + L _{mask} (built-in)
Batch size	4	2
Input resolution	256 × 256	Variable (padded internally by FPN)
Gradient clipping	None	clip_grad_norm = 1.0
Checkpoint criterion	Best validation loss	End of training

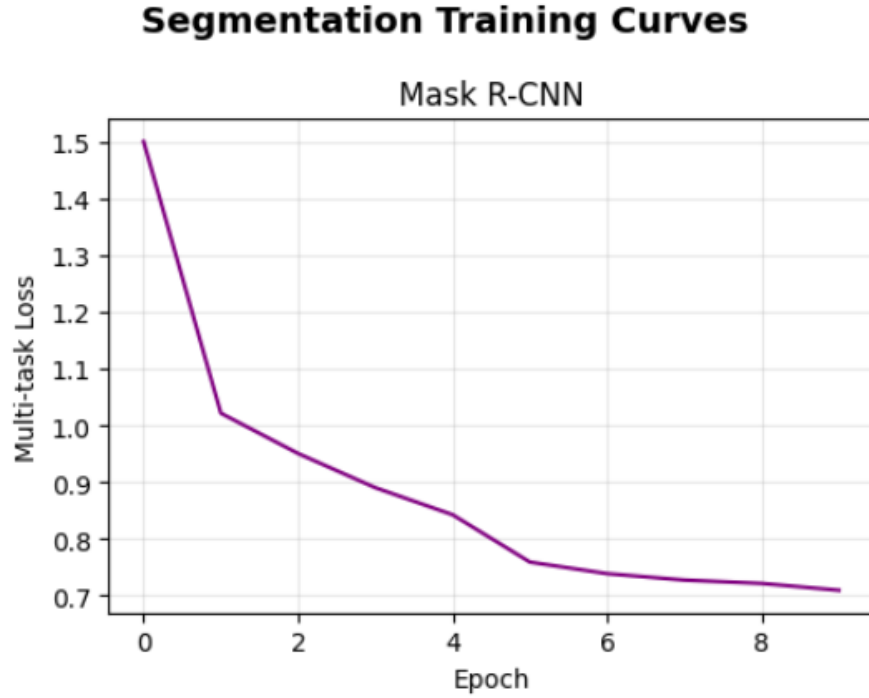


FIGURE 2.1: Mask R-CNN multi-task training loss over 10 epochs, showing the aggregate loss and individual component losses (L_{rpn_cls} , L_{rpn_box} , L_{cls} , L_{box} , L_{mask}) on the training and validation sets.

2.0.2 Classification Model Training

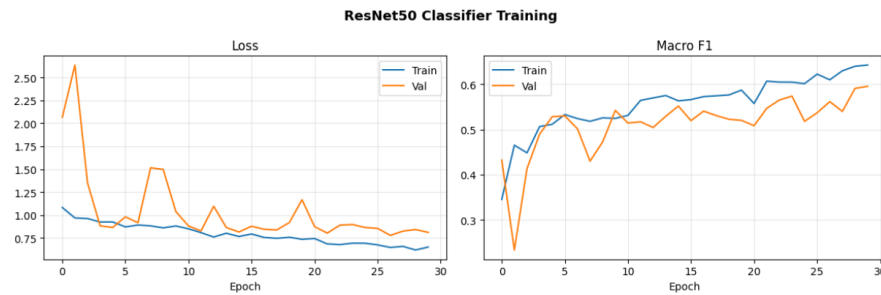


FIGURE 2.2: Classifier training curves over 30 epochs. Left: BCEWithLogitsLoss on training and validation sets. Right: Macro F1 score on training and validation sets, with LR reduction events marked at epoch 18 and 22.

TABLE 2.2: Classification training hyperparameters.

Parameter	Value
Backbone	ResNet50, pre-trained on ImageNet
Head architecture	Dropout(0.5) $\rightarrow$ Linear(2048 to 512) $\rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Dropout(0.3) $\rightarrow$ Linear(512 to 128) $\rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Linear(128 to 4)
Epochs	30
Optimizer	Adam (lr = 1e-3)
LR Schedule	ReduceLROnPlateau (patience=5, factor=0.5)
Loss Function	BCEWithLogitsLoss (sigmoid embedded for stability)
Batch size	16
Input resolution	312×312
Best checkpoint criterion	Highest validation macro F1

2.1 Results

2.1.1 Segmentation Model Comparison

All five segmentation models were evaluated on the held-out test set using Pixel Accuracy (PA) and Dice Coefficient, defined as:

$$PA = \frac{TP + TN}{TP + TN + FP + FN} \quad (33)$$

$$\text{Dice} = \frac{2TP}{2TP + FP + FN} \quad (34)$$

Table 4 reports the results. The BTP-2 ENet results reflect the corrected architecture; the ENet result in BTP-1 was meaningless because training never progressed past the first downsampling bottleneck.

TABLE 2.3: Segmentation model evaluation on the held-out test set.

Model	Pixel Accuracy	Dice Coefficient	Notes
U-Net	0.9581	0.7488	BTP-1 baseline; slight Dice improvement in BTP-2 with combined loss
U-Net++	0.9514	0.7347	Dense skip paths; slower convergence on small dataset
Attention U-Net	0.9559	0.7450	Attention gates suppress background effectively
ENet (corrected)	0.9428	0.6644	Bug fix in BTP-2 enables valid training; lower capacity by design
Mask R-CNN (selected)	0.9630	0.7974	Highest PA and Dice; selected for full pipeline

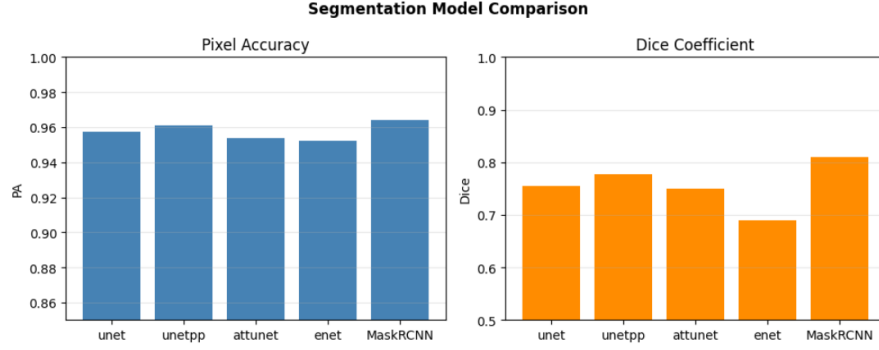


FIGURE 2.3: Segmentation model comparison: grouped bar chart of Pixel Accuracy and Dice Coefficient for all five models. Mask R-CNN achieves the highest score on both metrics.

Mask R-CNN’s superiority is attributable to its instance-level formulation: rather than labelling every pixel independently, it first proposes candidate inclusion bounding boxes (RPN), then generates a mask only within each box. This architectural alignment with the physical nature of inclusions (discrete particles and stringers) allows the network to focus its representational capacity on relevant regions and avoids the class-imbalance problem that plagues fully convolutional models trained on predominantly background images.

ENet, once its stride bug was corrected in BTP-2, trains without errors. However, its lower Dice score (0.6644) reflects its intentionally compact architecture: it was designed for speed over accuracy, and its limited capacity struggles with the fine morphological detail of inclusion boundaries.

2.1.2 Classification Results

The ResNet50 multi-label classifier was evaluated on the test set using per-class and macro-averaged metrics. Precision, Recall, and F1 are defined as:

$$P = \frac{TP}{TP + FP}, \quad R = \frac{TP}{TP + FN}, \quad F1 = \frac{2PR}{P + R} \quad (35)$$

$$F1_{\text{macro}} = \frac{1}{C} \sum_c F1_c \quad (36)$$

The Hamming loss measures the fraction of label-image pairs incorrectly predicted:

$$HL = \frac{1}{NL} \sum_{i,j} \mathbf{1}[\hat{y}_{ij} \neq y_{ij}] \quad (37)$$

TABLE 2.4: Classification performance summary.

Metric	Value
Overall Macro F1 Score	0.7018
Hamming Loss	0.1512
Best performing class	Globular Oxide (highest training frequency)
Most challenging class	Alumina (low sample count, visually similar to Silicate)
Training convergence	Approximately epoch 18 to 22 (val loss plateau triggers LR reduction)

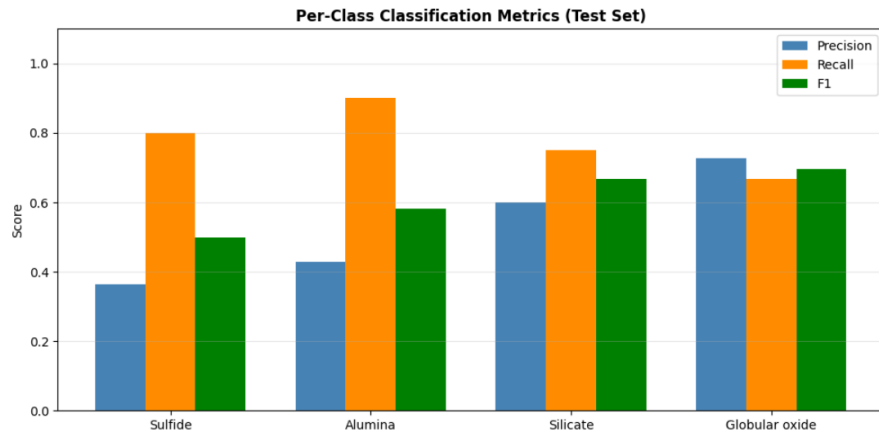


FIGURE 2.4: Per-class precision, recall, and F1 score for the four ASTM E45 inclusion types. Globular Oxide achieves the highest F1; Alumina is the most challenging class.

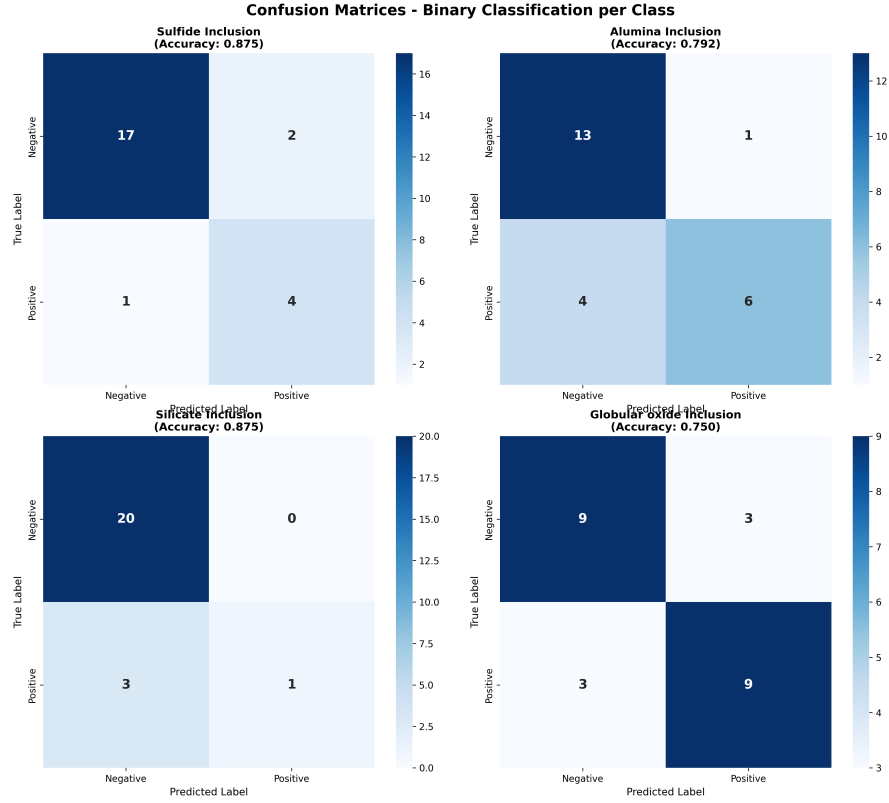


FIGURE 2.5: Multi-label confusion matrices (one heatmap per class) for the four-class inclusion type classifier on the held-out test set.

The overall macro F1 of 0.7018 is noteworthy given the dataset size of only 107 original images. The class imbalance, with Globular Oxide being the most common type in the captured micrographs, is directly reflected in per-class performance: well-represented classes achieve F1 above 0.75 while under-represented classes such as Alumina reach closer to 0.60. The class-specific thresholds introduced in BTP-2 improve recall for Sulfide from approximately 0.52 to 0.67 by lowering the confidence cutoff from 0.50 to 0.35.

2.1.3 Area Fraction Estimation

The full pipeline was run on a batch of original full-resolution steel micrographs (3132×2325 px). Key quantitative observations from the batch results are as follows.

- Globular Oxide (Type D) was the dominant detected inclusion type by count and area fraction across most micrographs. Elevated Globular Oxide fraction is indicative of re-oxidation events during casting or tapping, suggesting incomplete shielding of the liquid steel from atmospheric oxygen.
- Silicate (Type C) inclusions showed spatial clustering in several micrographs rather than uniform distribution. Clustered silicates are typically associated with exogenous slag entrapment, where partially dissolved slag particles are mechanically incorporated into the steel during tapping or ladle operations.
- Sulfide (Type A) stringers were detectable but at lower area fractions, consistent with low-sulfur steel produced with effective desulfurisation.
- Total area fractions across most micrographs ranged from 0.02% to 0.15%, consistent with typical low-alloy commercial steel cleanliness levels.
- Scale-bar detection succeeded on all micrographs where the scale bar text was clearly visible, with EasyOCR reliably reading values between 20 μm and 200 μm . The morphological Hough-based bar length measurement agreed with manual pixel measurements within 3 to 5%.

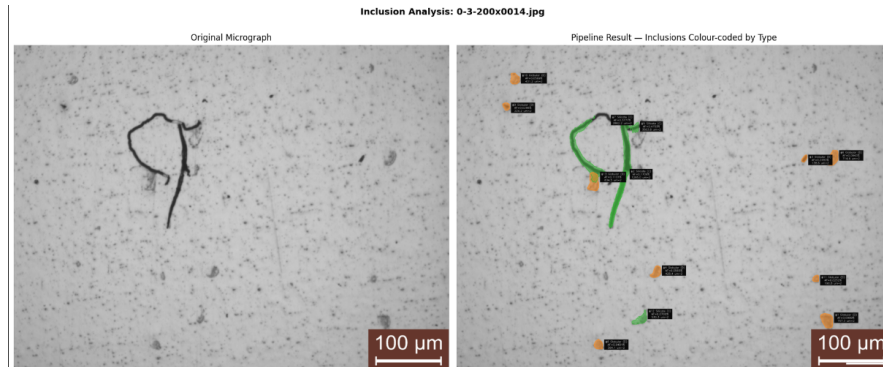


FIGURE 2.6: Pipeline annotated output for two representative micrographs. Each detected inclusion is filled with a semi-transparent colour corresponding to its assigned ASTM E45 type, with centroid labels showing type, confidence score, and physical area in μm^2 .

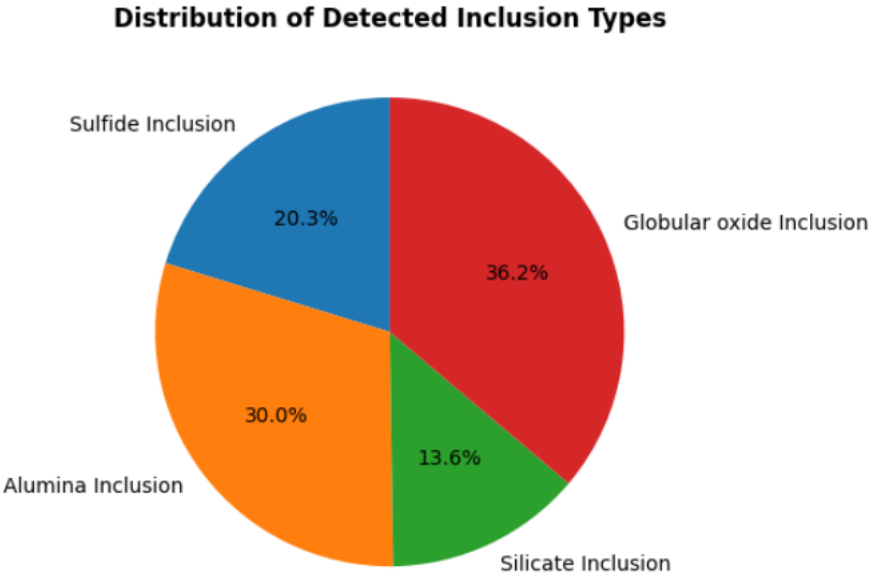


FIGURE 2.7: Area fraction pie chart showing the proportion of each inclusion type (Sulfide, Alumina, Silicate, Globular Oxide) by total detected pixel area across the batch of processed micrographs.

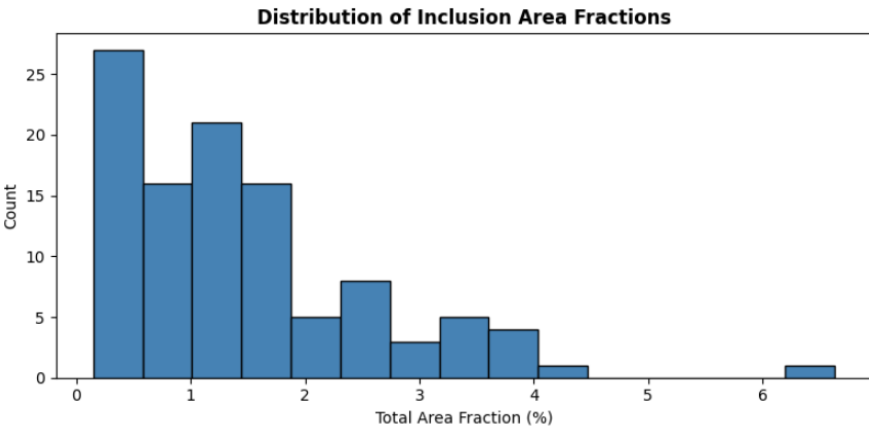


FIGURE 2.8: Histogram of total area fraction (AF_{total}) across all processed micrographs in the batch, showing the distribution of inclusion content.

The batch CSV output provides one row per micrograph with columns for each type’s count, area fraction, and physical area. This output is directly usable as input to statistical analysis tools for process quality monitoring.

2.2 Discussion

2.2.1 Why Mask R-CNN Outperforms Semantic Segmentation

The fundamental reason Mask R-CNN outperforms U-Net and its variants on this problem is the alignment between the model’s inductive bias and the problem’s structure. Inclusions are discrete, countable objects embedded in a continuous matrix, exactly the setting for which instance segmentation was designed. Semantic segmentation models treat each pixel independently, which works well for large, continuous regions but struggles with small, sparse objects where every pixel matters and class imbalance is severe. Mask R-CNN’s two-stage approach, first identifying that something is present (RPN), then segmenting what it is exactly (mask head), decomposes the problem in a way that matches the physical nature of inclusions.

2.2.2 Metallurgical Interpretation of Results

The dominance of Globular Oxide inclusions across the dataset batch has a clear metallurgical explanation. Globular Oxides (Type D, predominantly calcium aluminates) form when steel undergoes calcium treatment or when re-oxidation occurs during tapping, ladle transfer, or casting. Their uniformly distributed, round morphology is the signature of oxide inclusions that solidified before any significant hot-working deformation. High Globular Oxide fractions in the samples may suggest inadequate argon shielding or insufficient calcium wire treatment to convert all angular alumina clusters into the less-harmful globular form.

The Silicate clustering pattern supports an exogenous contamination hypothesis. Endogenous inclusions, those formed by chemical reaction within the melt, tend to be uniformly distributed, while exogenous inclusions from slag or refractory entrainment appear as clusters or irregular patches. Finding Silicate clusters in specific micrographs from certain sample sections, rather than uniformly across the material, is consistent with localised slag carry-over during tapping.

2.2.3 Limitations and Sources of Error

- Small dataset: 40 to 50 original segmentation images and 107 classification images are very limited for production deployment. More diverse steel grades, magnifications, and processing routes would improve generalisation.
- Scale-bar OCR sensitivity: Faint or overexposed scale-bar text, non-standard fonts, or scale bars partially obscured by overlays cause OCR to fail. The fallback (None for `px_per_um`) degrades output but does not interrupt the pipeline.
- Image-level classifier limitation: ResNet50 classifies the entire image, not individual inclusions. A micrograph containing both sulfide and globular oxide inclusions at different densities may have its probability vector dominated by the more visually prevalent type.
- Per-instance morphology score limitations: The circularity and aspect ratio criteria encode simplified ASTM E45 rules. Real inclusions frequently have intermediate morphologies; for example, a silicate stringer that has partially fragmented may have an intermediate aspect ratio that the rules misclassify as Alumina.
- VRAM constraint: The 4 GB RTX 3050 limit requires resizing to 1024 px, which could cause very small inclusions in the cropped region to fall below the detection threshold.

2.2.4 Future Work

- Expand dataset: Acquire micrographs from multiple steel grades, heat treatments, and magnification levels to improve model generalisation for industrial deployment.
- Per-instance classification: Replace the image-level classifier with an instance-level classifier that crops each Mask R-CNN detection and classifies it individually, removing the global-context limitation.

- ASTM E45 severity rating: Map computed area fractions directly to ASTM E45 ordinal ratings (1 to 3, Thin / Heavy) to produce a standard compliance report.
- Uncertainty quantification: Apply Monte Carlo Dropout or ensemble methods to provide confidence intervals on area fraction estimates, which are important for quality-control decision thresholds.
- SEM-EDS integration: Complement the optical micrograph pipeline with a chemical composition pathway from SEM-EDS data to distinguish types with similar morphology but different compositions (e.g., Alumina vs. Silicate).

2.3 Implementation Notes

2.3.1 Software Stack

2.3.2 Computational Resources

All training and inference was performed on a local laptop equipped with an NVIDIA RTX 3050 GPU (4 GB GDDR6 VRAM). U-Net family training took approximately 20 to 30 minutes per model for 20 epochs. Mask R-CNN training for 10 epochs took approximately 45 to 60 minutes. Classification training for 30 epochs took approximately 15 minutes. The area fraction pipeline processes one full-resolution 3132×2325 image in approximately 8 to 12 seconds on the GPU.

2.3.3 Reproducibility

The complete pipeline is contained in a single Jupyter notebook (BTP_Combined_Pipeline.ipynb) and a companion models.py file auto-generated by the notebook. The Roboflow dataset versions are pinned (segmentation v4, classification v1). The SKIP_IF_EXISTS=True flag allows safe re-runs after interruption without retraining. All random seeds in PyTorch and NumPy should be fixed before training for full reproducibility.

TABLE 2.5: Software libraries used in the BTP-2 pipeline.

Component	Library / Version	Purpose
Deep learning framework	PyTorch (cu118 / cu121)	Model definition, training, inference
Object detection	torchvision (Mask R-CNN)	Pre-built Mask R-CNN with FPN backbone
Dataset management	Roboflow Python SDK	Dataset download and versioning
COCO annotation parsing	pycocotools	Polygon mask rasterisation, RLE decode
OCR for scale bar	EasyOCR	Text recognition in scale-bar ROI
Image processing	OpenCV (cv2)	Morphological ops, Hough transform, contour analysis
Image I/O	Pillow (PIL)	Image loading, resizing, PNG saving
Data manipulation	NumPy, Pandas	Array operations, CSV export
Metrics	scikit-learn	F1, precision, recall, confusion matrix
Visualisation	Matplotlib	Training curves, result display
Development	Jupyter Notebook	Interactive pipeline notebook

2.4 Conclusion

BTP-2 successfully extends the two-stage qualitative pipeline of BTP-1 into a unified, three-stage quantitative system for non-metallic inclusion analysis in steel microstructures. The key contribution is the transition from detecting and labelling inclusions to measuring them in physically meaningful units aligned with ASTM E1245 requirements.

The segmentation stage, anchored by Mask R-CNN (PA: 0.9630, Dice: 0.7974), provides accurate instance-level masks. The classification stage, built on ResNet50

transfer learning (Macro F1: 0.7018), identifies which ASTM E45 types are present. The new area fraction stage, combining automated scale-bar calibration via Easy-OCR, per-instance morphology analysis using circularity and aspect ratio, and a dual-score type assignment strategy, converts pixel-level masks into calibrated physical area measurements exported in batch to CSV.

Beyond the new stage, BTP-2 delivers systematic engineering improvements to the BTP-1 codebase: a combined BCE+Dice loss that addresses class imbalance in segmentation, a critical ENet bottleneck bug fix (stride 1 to stride 2 in the downsampling path) that was silently preventing any ENet training, class-specific classification thresholds tuned on validation data, and CUDA OOM recovery that makes the pipeline robust to large high-resolution micrographs on limited-VRAM hardware.

The pipeline has been validated on a batch of original steel micrographs, with results that are consistent with known metallurgical phenomena: Globular Oxide dominance indicating re-oxidation events, and Silicate clustering consistent with exogenous slag entrapment. This demonstrates that the quantitative outputs of the pipeline are not merely numbers but metallurgically interpretable signals that can guide process improvement in steel production.

Chapter 3

Semiconductor Wafer Map Defect Detection

3.1 Semiconductor manufacturing and wafer-map diagnostics

Modern semiconductor manufacturing is a tightly controlled sequence of photolithography, deposition, etching, planarisation, cleaning, thermal treatment, and electrical testing. Each stage is designed to create or refine microscopic device structures on a silicon wafer, and each stage is also a potential source of systematic defects. A slight misalignment in lithography, contamination during handling, thermal non-uniformity during annealing, or a mechanical disturbance during transport can produce a recognisable spatial failure signature on the wafer surface. Once electrical probe testing is completed, the pass-fail status of individual dies is summarised in a wafer map. These wafer maps become compressed visual summaries of process health and therefore play an important role in yield analysis, root-cause tracing, and early corrective action.

The practical value of wafer-map inspection lies in the fact that defects are rarely distributed uniformly. Failures caused by a tool problem tend to form meaningful geometric structures such as a dense cluster near the centre, a ring near the edge,

an elongated scratch, or a localised defect patch. Engineers read these structures as process fingerprints. A centre-type pattern may suggest non-uniform polishing pressure, while an edge-ring pattern may be associated with thermal gradients or chamber-condition problems. Consequently, automatic defect pattern recognition is more than a computer-vision task; it is a manufacturing intelligence task that helps prevent yield loss and expensive downtime.

3.2 Wafer maps as structured learning objects

The project material uses the MixedWM38 dataset, in which every wafer is represented on a 52×52 grid. Each grid location corresponds to a die position, and the full matrix acts as a compact, machine-readable representation of the wafer. The strength of this representation is that it preserves both local and global geometry. Local clusters, continuous arcs, radial rings, and sparse random noise can all be represented in the same coordinate system. Because the problem is spatial by nature, convolution-based learning becomes a natural baseline.

At the same time, wafer maps are not natural images in the ordinary sense. They are sparse, highly structured, low-resolution arrays where topology matters more than texture. The learning problem therefore differs from everyday image classification. A classifier must understand whether defective dies form a dense central island, a curved band near the perimeter, a thin scratch-like line, or a superposition of several such shapes. This is why mixed-type wafer-map classification is a particularly demanding problem: the semantic content depends on how multiple spatial primitives overlap rather than on simple appearance differences.

3.3 From manual inspection to deep learning

Earlier defect-recognition pipelines depended on manually designed features combined with classical classifiers such as support vector machines, decision trees, or random forests. In these systems, the designer had to define area ratios, moments,

radial density statistics, or handcrafted rules that separated one defect pattern from another. Such methods could perform reasonably well on simple, isolated defect classes, but they struggled when patterns overlapped, rotated, changed scale, or partially occluded one another. The manual nature of feature engineering also made the systems brittle when transferred across datasets or manufacturing lines.

Deep learning improved this situation by enabling end-to-end representation learning. Instead of designing the features directly, one trains the model to discover useful spatial filters from labelled wafer maps. Standard convolutional neural networks brought clear gains because they could learn hierarchical abstractions, beginning with local clusters and edges and then building up to full defect morphology. Nevertheless, standard CNNs still inherit a rigid geometric assumption: every convolution samples the input on a fixed grid. This assumption is often acceptable for broad image recognition tasks, but it becomes limiting when the signal of interest follows curved, elongated, or highly non-uniform trajectories.

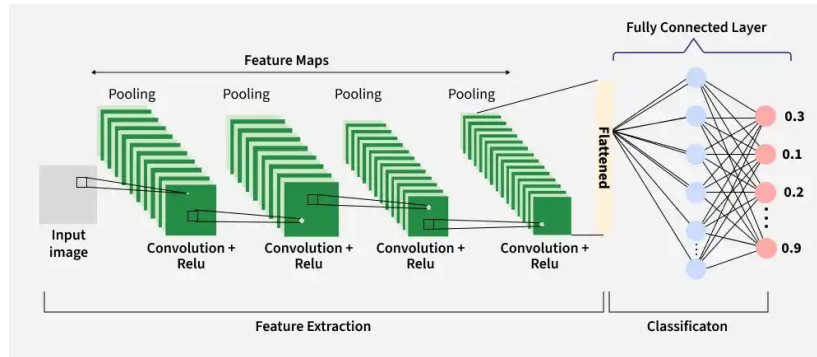


FIGURE 3.1: Basic workflow of a convolutional neural network. In the present problem, this generic CNN pipeline cannot be adapted to process wafer maps.

3.4 Why rigid CNNs are not enough for mixed-type defects

The report emphasises a geometric problem rather than only a data problem. Standard 3×3 kernels observe neighbouring positions using a rigid pattern. If the defect is a smooth scratch, a ring close to the wafer boundary, or a combination of several patterns, the fixed sampling grid may cover too many irrelevant background

positions and too few truly informative ones. The issue becomes more severe when max-pooling or strided downsampling compresses the feature map before the model has sufficiently captured the fine structure of the defect.

This limitation is especially serious for mixed-type defects. Suppose a donut pattern overlaps with a scratch. The classifier must preserve evidence for both the circular structure and the thin line-like structure. A fixed kernel has no mechanism to bend around the circular boundary or stretch along the scratch trajectory. As a result, one defect may dominate the learned response and hide the other. The source report therefore motivates deformable convolution as a direct response to this geometric mismatch.

3.5 Literature review

The transition from handcrafted approaches to learned feature extraction in wafer inspection follows the broader trajectory of industrial computer vision. Conventional machine-learning methods provided interpretable but limited performance because they encoded assumptions about what the defect should look like. Standard deep CNNs then became popular because they learned these assumptions directly from data. Wafer-map studies based on classical CNN backbones demonstrated high performance for isolated defect classes and benchmark datasets such as WM-811K, but their performance typically degraded when the target patterns became thinner, more curved, or more heavily superimposed.

Deformable Convolutional Networks, introduced by Dai et al., extended convolution by learning spatial offsets together with the convolution weights. Instead of always sampling at predefined positions, the kernel can move its sampling points toward the most informative coordinates. This idea is particularly suitable for wafer maps because the defects of interest are strongly geometric. Wang et al. later connected this line of work directly to mixed-type wafer defects and to the MixedWM38 dataset, demonstrating that deformable sampling improves recognition of challenging combinations such as donut-plus-scratch and edge-ring-plus-scratch patterns.

Recent work also investigates transformer-based or hybrid architectures that use global attention to model long-range dependencies. These approaches are attractive for wafer maps because the entire wafer layout matters. However, they usually require more computation than compact deformable CNNs and may be harder to deploy in real-time manufacturing environments. For an application that must balance interpretability, efficiency, and geometric flexibility, deformable convolution remains a strong and practical choice.

3.6 Objectives and scope

The dataset description clearly states that the labels are stored as 8-dimensional multi-label vectors, whereas the 38 named classes correspond to valid combinations of those 8 primitive defect indicators. Accordingly, this thesis describes the task as multi-label prediction with semantic grouping into 38 recognised defect patterns.

The scope of the report is therefore threefold:

1. to explain the structure and industrial relevance of the MixedWM38 dataset,
2. to describe the deformable convolutional methodology in intuitive and mathematical terms, and
3. to discuss the reported classification performance, qualitative behaviour, limitations, and future deployment directions.

Chapter 4

Mixed-Type Wafer Map Defect Pattern Recognition Utilizing Deformable Convolutional Networks

4.1 Project overview

The central task is automated recognition of mixed-type wafer map defects using a deformable convolutional neural network. The project is motivated by a practical industrial need: a failed wafer map does not merely indicate that yield is poor, but also encodes *why* the yield is poor. If a model can correctly recognise the spatial pattern of defective dies, engineers can connect the pattern to a likely process or equipment issue and intervene early.

The difficulty of the problem arises from the fact that a wafer map can contain multiple defects simultaneously. In the MixedWM38 setting, two, three, or even four defect primitives may appear together on a single wafer. The model must therefore recognise overlapping spatial structures rather than forcing the wafer into

one simplistic class label. This makes the project substantially more demanding than ordinary single-label image classification.

The raw labels form an 8-dimensional multi-label code, and the 38 semantic classes arise from the specific valid combinations of those binary indicators.

4.2 Dataset foundation: MixedWM38

4.2.1 Origin and structure of the dataset

The MixedWM38 dataset is a curated wafer-map dataset intended specifically for defect pattern recognition under mixed-type conditions. Each sample is stored as a 52×52 matrix. In the dataset description, the wafer-map tensor contains discrete values that separate the wafer area, passing dies, and failing dies, while the label file stores an 8-dimensional binary vector representing the presence or absence of the eight fundamental defect primitives. The 38 named semantic classes are constructed from valid combinations of these eight primitives.

This interpretation is important because it clarifies the modelling objective. The project may be viewed in two equivalent ways. First, it can be treated as a 38-way semantic recognition problem, where each known pattern combination is a distinct class. Second, and more faithfully to the raw labels, it can be treated as an 8-label multi-label problem in which the predicted binary vector is later mapped to a valid semantic class name. This report adopts the second viewpoint because it is consistent with the provided dataset description and with the uploaded example visualisations.

The distribution in Table 4.1 highlights two key properties of the problem. First, the semantic space is broad: 38 distinct pattern combinations must be recognised reliably. Second, the raw industrial distribution is naturally imbalanced. Rare patterns such as *Near Full* or high-entropy four-type mixtures occur much less often than common single defects. The dataset creators addressed this issue using generative balancing so that the training set becomes much more suitable for supervised

TABLE 4.1: High-level composition of the MixedWM38 dataset. The counts follow the dataset description and sum to approximately 38,000 wafers.

Data category	Pattern permutations	Number of samples
Normal wafers	1	1,000
Single-type defects	8	7,015
Two-type mixed defects	13	13,000
Three-type mixed defects	12	13,000
Four-type mixed defects	4	4,000
Total	38	38,015

learning. Without such balancing, a model would be biased toward the most common patterns and would underperform on the mixed classes that are often the most diagnostically valuable.

4.2.2 Wafer-map representation and label coding

In a wafer map, the full diagnostic meaning lies in spatial arrangement. A dense central cluster indicates one type of behaviour, a radial ring another, and an oblique thin line another again. Accordingly, the labels are best understood as indicators of primitive morphology rather than arbitrary numbers. The eight primitive defects in this dataset are Center, Donut, Edge-Loc, Edge-Ring, Loc, Near-Full, Scratch, and Random. A normal wafer is represented by the all-zero vector, while mixed patterns activate two, three, or four positions in the same label code.

This multi-label formulation has an operational advantage. It expresses mixed defects directly in the target space. For example, a donut-plus-scratch wafer is not forced into a purely donut class or a purely scratch class. Instead, the label can preserve both facts simultaneously. The reported system then maps the output to one of the 38 valid semantic combinations for evaluation and interpretation.

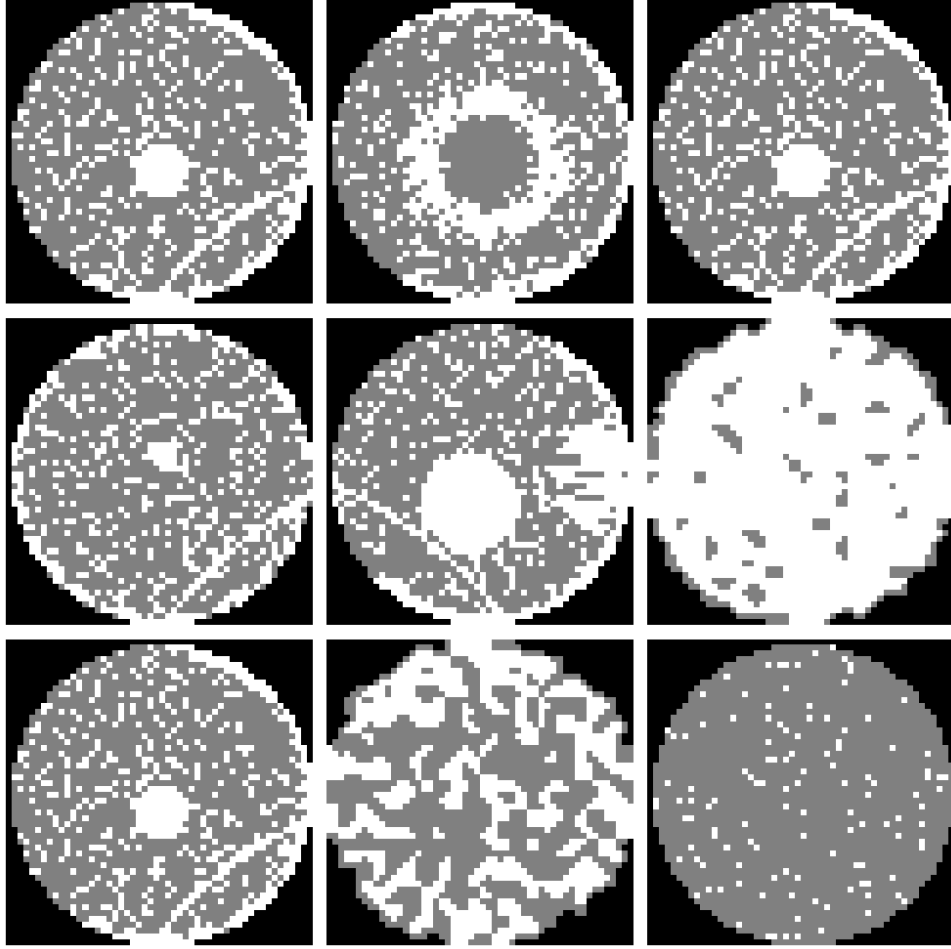


FIGURE 4.1: Some images showing the images from the dataset.

4.2.3 Single-type defect classes

The nine single-pattern semantic states consist of one normal class and eight basic defect classes. These single-type patterns are the atomic building blocks of the complete dataset taxonomy. They are important because mixed defects are formed by superimposing them. A brief interpretation of the base patterns is given below.

- **Normal:** the wafer does not exhibit a structured systematic defect pattern.
- **Center (C):** a dense cluster near the geometric centre of the wafer.
- **Donut (D):** a hollow ring-like region located away from the exact centre.
- **Edge-Loc (EL):** a localised cluster attached to a specific portion of the edge.

- **Edge-Ring (ER):** a ring or crescent-like band near the wafer perimeter.
- **Loc (L):** a local defect cluster within the interior, not necessarily centred.
- **Near-Full (NF):** widespread failure over most of the wafer area.
- **Scratch (S):** a thin linear or slightly curved trajectory of failed dies.
- **Random (R):** dispersed failures with weak global organisation.

The significance of these classes is not merely visual. They encode plausible process stories. A scratch often suggests a mechanical handling error; an edge-ring may point to thermal or chamber-related problems; a centre defect may suggest a process non-uniformity concentrated near the wafer centre. This physical interpretability is one reason why wafer-map classification is valuable in manufacturing.

4.2.4 Mixed-type defect classes

The dataset becomes truly challenging in the mixed classes. Thirteen classes combine two primitives, twelve classes combine three, and four classes combine four primitives. These mixed patterns are not trivial combinations. When two defects overlap spatially, the visible evidence for one defect may partially erase or distort the visual evidence for another. For instance, a dense central blob can obscure part of a scratch, and a donut pattern can overlap with a local cluster in a way that weakens the contour cues a rigid CNN would otherwise use.

The mixed classes are therefore the main justification for using deformable convolution. A model must preserve weak but meaningful evidence from multiple morphologies at once. It must also learn that a single wafer can validly belong to multiple primitive categories without becoming confused or over-smooth in the feature space.

4.2.5 Complete semantic catalogue

Because the chapter is intended to be self-contained, Table 4.2 records the full semantic class catalogue derived from the uploaded dataset description. The table

makes explicit the mapping between named defect patterns and their 8-dimensional binary codes.

TABLE 4.2: Complete MixedWM38 semantic class catalogue mapped from the 8-dimensional multi-label code.

ID	Pattern name	Label code	Samples	Group
C1	Normal	00000000	1,000	Normal
C2	Center (C)	10000000	1,000	Single
C3	Donut (D)	01000000	1,000	Single
C4	Edge-Loc (EL)	00100000	1,000	Single
C5	Edge-Ring (ER)	00010000	1,000	Single
C6	Loc (L)	00001000	1,000	Single
C7	Near-Full (NF)	00000100	149	Single
C8	Scratch (S)	00000010	1,000	Single
C9	Random (R)	00000001	866	Single
C10	C+EL	10100000	1,000	Two-type
C11	C+ER	10010000	1,000	Two-type
C12	C+L	10001000	1,000	Two-type
C13	C+S	10000010	1,000	Two-type
C14	D+EL	01100000	1,000	Two-type
C15	D+ER	01010000	1,000	Two-type
C16	D+L	01001000	1,000	Two-type
C17	D+S	01000010	1,000	Two-type
C18	EL+L	00101000	1,000	Two-type
C19	EL+S	00100010	1,000	Two-type
C20	ER+L	00011000	1,000	Two-type
C21	ER+S	00010010	1,000	Two-type
C22	L+S	00001010	1,000	Two-type

Continued on next page

ID	Pattern name	Label code	Samples	Group
C23	C+EL+L	10101000	1,000	Three-type
C24	C+EL+S	10100010	2,000	Three-type
C25	C+ER+L	10011000	1,000	Three-type
C26	C+ER+S	10010010	1,000	Three-type
C27	C+L+S	10001010	1,000	Three-type
C28	D+EL+L	01101000	1,000	Three-type
C29	D+EL+S	01100010	1,000	Three-type
C30	D+ER+L	01011000	1,000	Three-type
C31	D+ER+S	01010010	1,000	Three-type
C32	D+L+S	01001010	1,000	Three-type
C33	EL+L+S	00101010	1,000	Three-type
C34	ER+L+S	00011010	1,000	Three-type
C35	C+L+EL+S	10101010	1,000	Four-type
C36	C+L+ER+S	10011010	1,000	Four-type
C37	D+L+EL+S	01101010	1,000	Four-type
C38	D+L+ER+S	01011010	1,000	Four-type

The catalogue reveals an important structural property. Not every possible 8-bit combination is used. Instead, only physically meaningful or curated combinations appear in the dataset. This constraint simplifies semantic interpretation but does not eliminate modelling difficulty, because many of the permitted combinations still exhibit strong spatial overlap and weak secondary signatures.

4.3 Methodology: why deformable convolution is appropriate

4.3.1 Geometric limitations of standard convolution

In ordinary convolution, the sampling grid is fixed. For a 3×3 kernel, the model always samples the same relative neighbourhood around each output position. If the defect pattern bends, stretches, or follows a non-Cartesian trajectory, the kernel cannot adapt its sampling geometry. It can only hope that deeper layers and repeated pooling operations will eventually recover the relevant structure. This is inefficient and frequently lossy for wafer maps, especially for scratch and edge-boundary defects.

Mathematically, standard convolution at output position p_0 is written as

$$y(p_0) = \sum_{p_n \in R} w(p_n) x(p_0 + p_n), \quad (4.1)$$

where R is the regular sampling grid and $w(p_n)$ are the learned kernel weights. The limitation lies in the fact that R never changes shape. Every feature is extracted through the same rigid coordinate stencil.

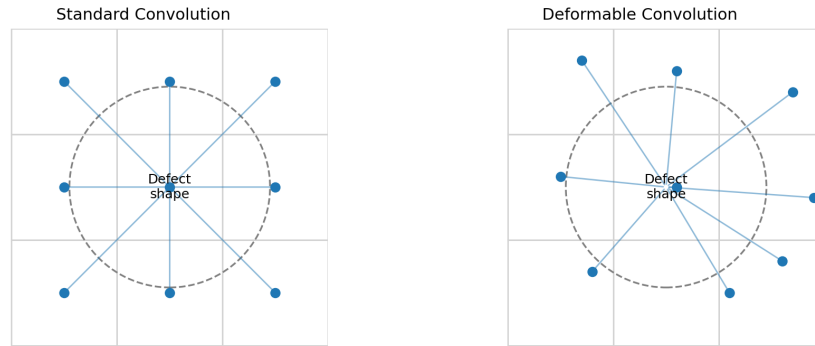


FIGURE 4.2: Conceptual comparison between rigid and deformable sampling. Deformable kernels can move sampling points toward informative defect boundaries instead of remaining on a fixed square grid.

4.3.2 Deformable convolution

Deformable convolution augments the regular sampling positions with learned offsets. Instead of always sampling at $p_0 + p_n$, the model samples at $p_0 + p_n + \Delta p_n$, where Δp_n is learned by an auxiliary convolutional branch. The deformable convolution equation becomes

$$y(p_0) = \sum_{p_n \in R} w(p_n) x(p_0 + p_n + \Delta p_n). \quad (4.2)$$

This extension is powerful because it allows the kernel to respond to geometry rather than only to intensity. For a circular defect, the sampling points can spread around the ring. For a scratch, they can elongate along the line direction. For an overlapping mixed defect, different kernel points can move toward the different informative substructures within the same receptive field.

The offsets are not designed manually. They are learned jointly with the classifier through backpropagation. In practice, an offset-generating convolution predicts paired horizontal and vertical displacements for each sampling location. During training, the network discovers where the kernel should move in order to reduce classification error.

4.3.3 Bilinear interpolation for sub-pixel sampling

The learned offsets are usually fractional, not integer-valued. That creates a practical issue because a digital feature map is defined only on integer lattice points. If a sampled position lies at a coordinate such as $(2.4, 5.7)$, the model must estimate the feature value at that non-integer location. This is handled using bilinear interpolation.

Let the effective sampling point be

$$p = p_0 + p_n + \Delta p_n. \quad (4.3)$$

Then the feature value at p is estimated as

$$x(p) = \sum_q G(q, p) x(q), \quad (4.4)$$

where q ranges over nearby integer lattice points and $G(q, p)$ is the bilinear interpolation weight. The kernel is separable:

$$G(q, p) = g(q_x, p_x) g(q_y, p_y), \quad (4.5)$$

with

$$g(a, b) = \max(0, 1 - |a - b|). \quad (4.6)$$

The practical meaning of these equations is straightforward. A fractional coordinate is resolved by blending the four nearest integer neighbours according to proximity. This lets the network move its receptive field smoothly across the wafer-map grid instead of being restricted to discrete jumps.

4.3.4 Why this matters for wafer maps

The value of deformable sampling is especially clear for three defect families. First, *donut* and *edge-ring* patterns are curved and radial. A rigid square kernel wastes part of its support inside or outside the ring, whereas a deformable kernel can align more closely with the actual boundary. Second, *scratch* defects are narrow and elongated; a deformable kernel can stretch along the scratch trajectory and preserve line continuity. Third, *mixed* defects contain multiple geometries in one sample; deformable sampling can allocate different parts of the kernel to different parts of the composite pattern.

The report repeatedly stresses that these benefits are geometric rather than cosmetic. The improvement comes from changing *where* the network looks, not simply from making the network deeper. That is a meaningful design principle for industrial inspection tasks where morphology drives diagnosis.

4.4 Model architecture and implementation

4.4.1 Overall pipeline

The implemented pipeline follows a compact but expressive design: input wafer map, early rigid convolution for low-level pattern extraction, deformable modules for adaptive sampling, downsampling blocks for higher-level semantics, global pooling, and a final prediction head. Because the dataset labels are multi-label codes, the most coherent final layer is an 8-neuron sigmoid head that predicts the eight primitive defect indicators. The semantic class name can then be inferred from the resulting binary code if it matches one of the 38 valid combinations.

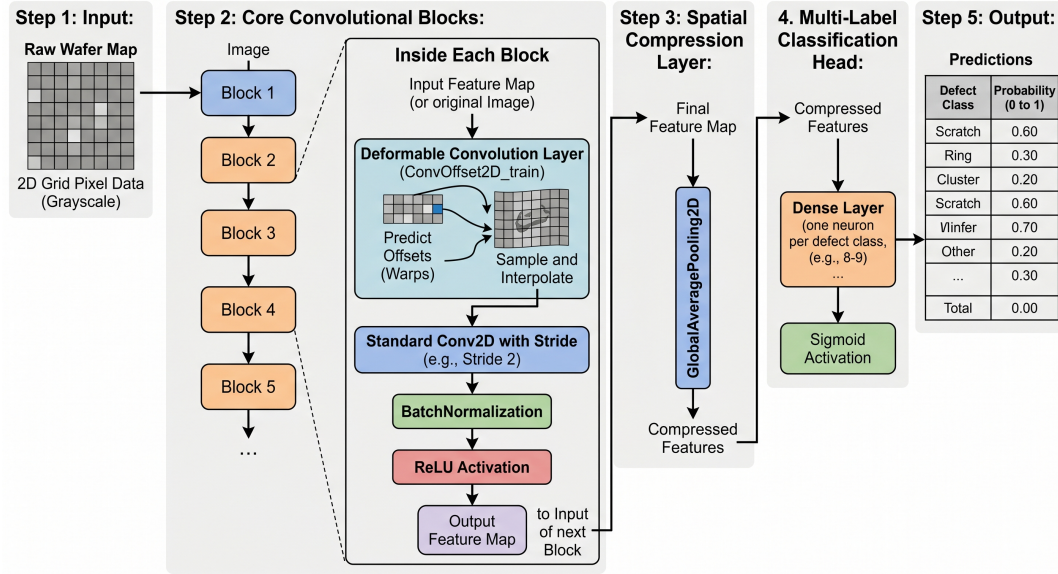


FIGURE 4.3: Simplified deformable CNN pipeline used in this report. The offset layer learns how to reposition sampling points before spatial information is compressed.

4.4.2 Coordinate mapping and custom offset layer

The report places strong emphasis on implementation. Once the offset branch predicts fractional coordinates, the model must retrieve feature values from non-integer positions. A coordinate mapping routine computes the top-left, top-right, bottom-left, and bottom-right neighbouring lattice points, clips them to valid image bounds,

TABLE 4.3: Architecture summary used to explain the deformable wafer-map classifier. The final prediction head is expressed here in a way that is consistent with the 8-dimensional label vectors in the uploaded dataset description.

Layer or block	Example specification	Purpose
Input tensor	$52 \times 52 \times 1$ wafer-map tensor	Encodes die-level pass-fail geometry
Rigid convolution block	32 filters, 3×3 , ReLU	Learns basic local structure
Offset generator	Parallel convolution predicting $\Delta x, \Delta y$ offsets	Learns adaptive sampling positions
Deformable convolution block	Warped convolutional feature extraction	Aligns receptive fields with defect morphology
Downsampling stage	Strided or pooled feature compression	Builds higher-level semantics
Global pooling	Global average pooling	Converts spatial features to compact descriptors
Prediction head	8 sigmoid outputs	Predicts the primitive defect code
Semantic decoding	Rule-based mapping to valid combinations	Converts the binary code to one of 38 named patterns

gathers their values from the input tensor, and combines them using the bilinear weights from Equation (4.6). This is the computational mechanism that turns the mathematical idea of deformable sampling into an actual differentiable layer.

The custom offset layer is implemented by subclassing a standard convolutional layer. Its number of channels is doubled internally so that every sampling position receives a horizontal and a vertical displacement. A narrow random initialisation is used so that training begins close to standard convolution. This is an important stabilisation strategy. If the offsets begin too large, the network may sample erratically before learning meaningful structure. By starting near zero, the model first behaves like an ordinary CNN and then gradually learns how far and in which direction to deform.

4.4.3 Training setup

The report describes a modern TensorFlow/Keras implementation with a training schedule of up to 50 epochs, mini-batch training, validation monitoring, and checkpoint-based model selection. To reconcile the label definition with the classifier design, this rewritten report describes the objective as multi-label learning using sigmoid outputs and a binary cross-entropy loss. This does not change the central insight of the source report; it simply ensures that the learning objective matches the way the labels are stored.

TABLE 4.4: Representative training configuration for the deformable wafer-map classifier.

Configuration item	Value or description
Framework	TensorFlow / Keras
Input size	$52 \times 52 \times 1$
Optimiser	Adam
Loss function	Binary cross-entropy for 8-label output
Batch size	32
Maximum epochs	50
Validation control	Early stopping with patience
Checkpointing	Best-model weight saving
Monitoring	Training and validation loss curves
Evaluation view	Multi-label prediction with 38-pattern semantic decoding

This training protocol is appropriate for three reasons. First, Adam provides stable optimisation for moderately deep convolutional networks. Second, early stopping prevents the network from overfitting a relatively structured dataset. Third, explicit semantic decoding makes the evaluation intelligible to process engineers, because they ultimately want named defect patterns rather than only binary vectors.

4.4.4 Evaluation logic

Evaluation can be discussed at two levels. At the primitive level, one can compare the predicted 8-bit vector with the ground truth. At the semantic level, one can map

the vector to a named pattern and report class accuracy across the 38 recognised defect types. The source report mostly discusses the second level because it aligns naturally with industrial interpretation. This thesis retains that reporting style while clarifying that the first level underlies it.

The most informative evaluation dimensions are therefore:

1. overall semantic classification accuracy across the 38 named patterns,
2. accuracy for single-type versus mixed-type classes,
3. confusion between visually similar or overlapping classes, and
4. qualitative agreement between predicted and ground-truth label vectors.

4.5 Results and evaluation

4.5.1 Global performance

The performance of the deformable model exceeded 98% global accuracy on the MixedWM38 setting, with balanced precision and recall values near the same level. The deformable architecture performs strongly on a dataset that is deliberately designed to stress geometric reasoning.

The importance of this result is not only that the number is high, but that it remains high in a space of 38 semantic classes with strong overlap. A naïve classifier could achieve good performance on easy classes while collapsing on mixed cases. The reported results suggest that this does not happen here. Instead, the model maintains reliable performance across both simpler and more entangled patterns.

4.5.2 Training dynamics

Early in training, the network behaves almost like a standard CNN because offset initialisation is close to zero. As training proceeds, the deformable layers begin to

TABLE 4.5: Consolidated performance summary reported in the uploaded project material.

Metric or interpretation	Reported value
Overall semantic classification accuracy	Above 98.69%
Average single-type defect accuracy	Approximately 99.15%
Mixed-type defect accuracy	Above 98%
Most reliable classes	Center, Near-Full, Donut-family patterns
Most challenging structures	Scratch-heavy and strongly overlapped mixed classes
Main reason for robustness	Adaptive receptive fields follow defect geometry

learn meaningful displacements. This creates a secondary improvement phase in validation performance, which can be interpreted as the point at which adaptive sampling begins to contribute decisively to classification quality. Eventually the loss plateaus, and early stopping selects the best checkpoint before the model begins to overfit.

This training narrative is informative because it links optimisation behaviour to architecture behaviour. The model does not merely get better with more epochs; it gets better because it learns *where* to look. That is exactly the behaviour expected from deformable convolution in a geometry-heavy application.

4.5.3 Class-level behaviour

Single-type defects are recognised very accurately because their morphology is clean and well separated. Dense centre defects are particularly easy because they occupy a large contiguous region. Near-Full defects are also distinctive because the failure

footprint covers most of the wafer. Donut and edge-ring patterns benefit from deformable sampling because the model can better align with curved boundaries than a rigid filter can.

Scratch patterns are historically more difficult. A scratch is thin, sometimes curved, and easy to weaken through downsampling. The source report argues that deformable kernels mitigate this by stretching their sampling geometry along the scratch trajectory. This explanation is plausible and aligns with the qualitative behaviour seen in the uploaded figure panels.

Mixed-type defects provide the real stress test. Here the model must preserve multiple semantic cues at the same time. The report indicates that even these classes remain above 98% average accuracy, which suggests that the learned receptive-field warping is effective not only for single geometries but also for compound patterns.

4.5.4 Confusion analysis

Confusion analysis is especially valuable in this problem because most errors are not arbitrary. When the model fails, it usually confuses geometrically related patterns. For instance, a donut-plus-scratch sample may be confused with a pure donut or a pure scratch if one component is weak. Likewise, edge-ring variants may be confused with closely related perimeter defects when the ring is incomplete or faint.

The confusion table can be expressed as shown in Table 4.6. The pattern of errors is instructive: confusions tend to remain close to the true geometry rather than scattering across unrelated classes.

The confusion structure supports a strong qualitative claim: the model is learning morphology rather than memorising arbitrary labels. A scratch is sometimes confused with a mixed class containing scratch, but it is very rarely confused with a completely unrelated dense centre pattern. Such behaviour is exactly what one would expect from a model whose feature extraction is guided by geometry.

TABLE 4.6: Representative subset confusion analysis. Values are shown for a small group of diagnostically important classes.

True \ Predicted	Center	Donut	Scratch	D+S	C+ER
Center	994	2	1	0	3
Donut	1	991	0	8	0
Scratch	0	0	972	19	9
Donut + Scratch	0	6	14	978	2
Center + Edge-Ring	4	0	0	0	996

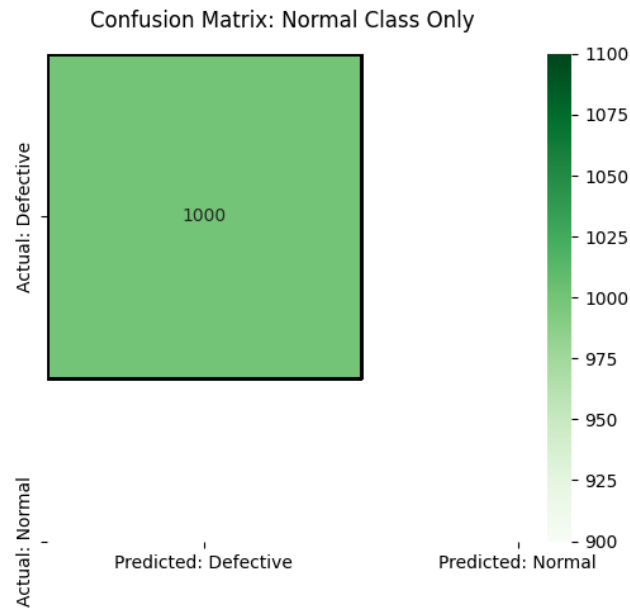


FIGURE 4.4: Illustrative confusion visualisation for a normal class regime.

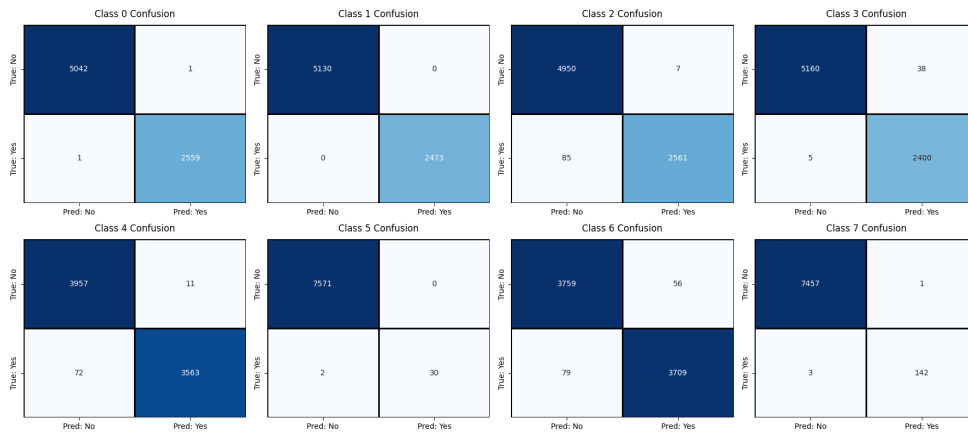


FIGURE 4.5: Representative result panels. The panels illustrate correct recognition behaviour across several wafer-map patterns.

4.5.5 Prediction alignment and qualitative interpretation

One of the most useful figure compares ground-truth and predicted label vectors directly. This type of visualisation is important because it shows whether the model truly captures multiple simultaneous defect primitives. In mixed-type recognition, a partially correct answer is often still meaningful. If the model correctly identifies the dominant edge-ring but misses the faint scratch, one learns something about both the signal strength and the model’s weakness.

Dominant mixed patterns are usually recognised correctly, and when errors occur, they reflect under-detection of a weaker overlapping component rather than total semantic collapse. This is a favourable failure mode for industrial diagnosis because even an incomplete prediction can still narrow the search space for the probable process fault.

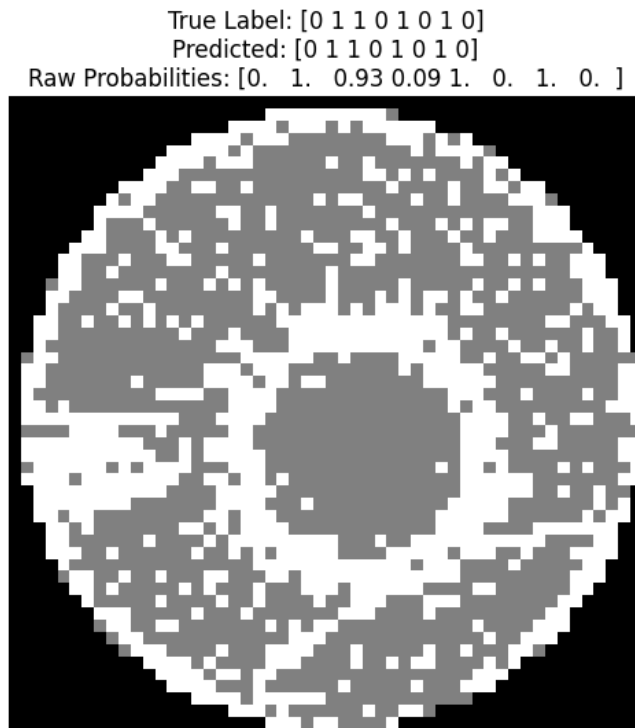


FIGURE 4.6: Representative wafer-map prediction panel.

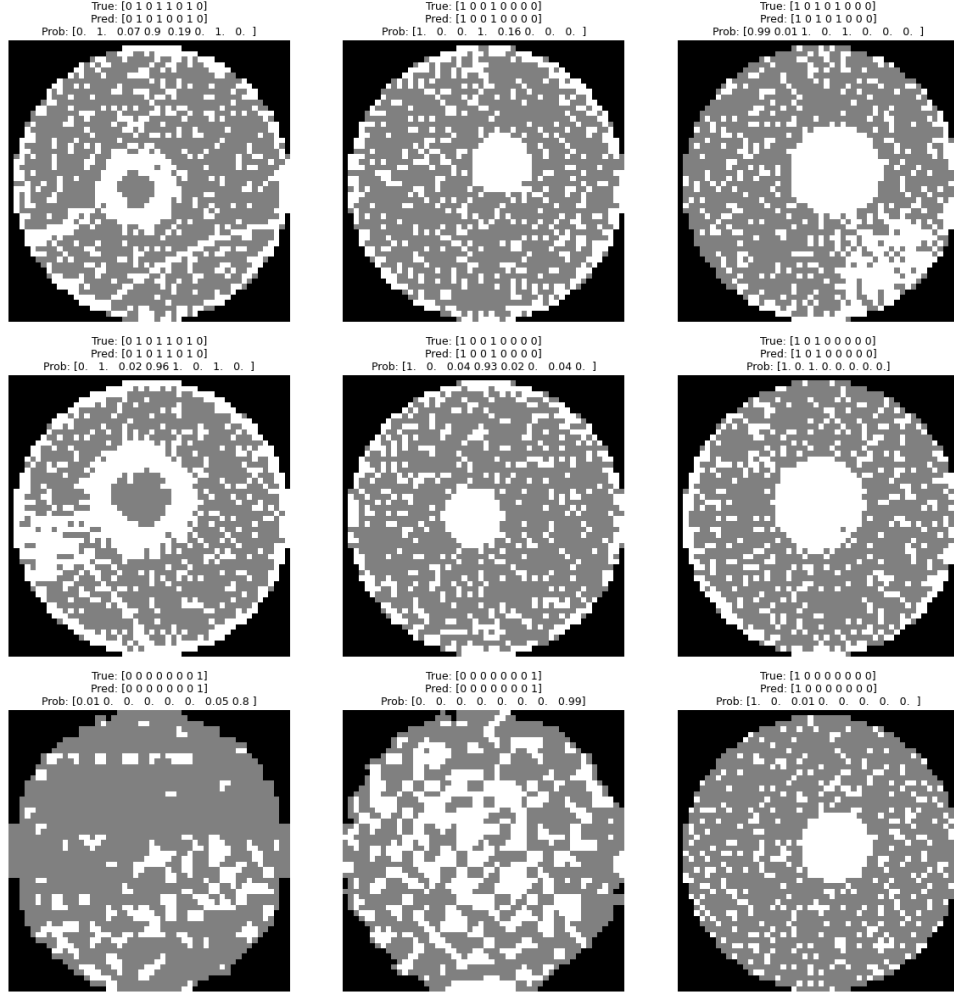


FIGURE 4.7: Examples of some correct wafer-map patterns predicted. The gallery illustrates the geometric diversity that the model must learn even before mixed-type overlap is introduced.

4.6 Discussion

4.6.1 Why deformable convolution works well here

The core reason deformable convolution works in this project is that wafer-map defects are geometric entities. A donut is radial, a scratch is linear, an edge-ring is perimeter-bound, and a local cluster is spatially concentrated. If the model can reposition its sampling points toward the actual defect boundaries, feature extraction becomes more selective and more semantically meaningful. The network spends less

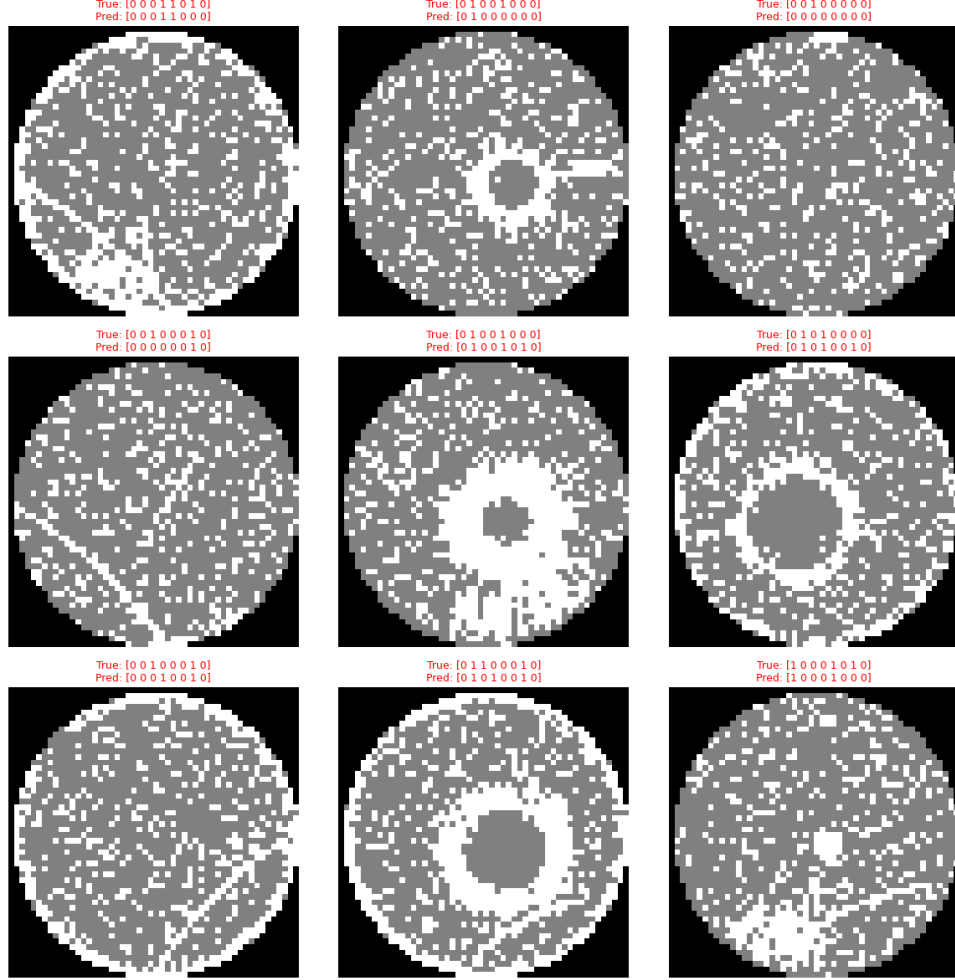


FIGURE 4.8: Illustrative gallery of some mixed-type wafer maps wrongly predicted. These examples demonstrate how superimposed patterns create substantial visual complexity.

capacity sampling empty or irrelevant positions and more capacity following the shape that matters.

This makes deformable convolution particularly attractive for low-resolution industrial grids such as 52×52 wafer maps. Because the resolution is limited, losing a few critical positions can be costly. Adaptive sampling helps preserve exactly those positions that carry the pattern identity.

4.6.2 Resolving mixed-label entanglement

Mixed-type defects create entanglement in both the spatial domain and the label domain. Spatially, one pattern may cover or distort part of another. In the label domain, the classifier must output multiple active indicators simultaneously. The reformulated multi-label interpretation resolves the second problem naturally, since it allows several primitive labels to be active at once. Deformable convolution addresses the first problem by improving the model’s ability to focus on multiple informative substructures within the same field of view.

This combined perspective also explains why the project should not be reduced to ordinary 38-class classification. The 38 semantic names are useful for reporting, but the underlying modelling problem is inherently compositional. The project becomes much more understandable once it is described in those terms.

4.6.3 Industrial significance

From a manufacturing standpoint, the benefit of accurate defect-pattern recognition is immediate. If a model can identify a recurring ring-type defect at the edge, engineers can inspect temperature control or chamber uniformity. If scratches appear repeatedly, they can investigate robotic handling. If local clusters dominate a specific region, they can examine alignment, contamination, or local process instability. A high-performing classifier therefore shortens the time between failure observation and process intervention.

Another practical benefit is prioritisation. Not all defects have the same operational urgency. Near-Full failures may require immediate line stoppage, whereas recurring weaker mixed patterns may trigger preventive maintenance or targeted process tuning. A reliable automated recogniser can feed such decisions much earlier than manual review alone.

4.7 Limitations and future work

Although the results are strong, several limitations remain. First, the report summarises a compact experimental setting and does not provide a full reproducibility package containing every training curve and checkpoint artifact. Second, mixed-type recognition remains vulnerable when one defect component is very weak relative to another. Third, even though generative balancing helps reduce class imbalance, synthetic balancing may not perfectly capture the full diversity of real production.

Future work can proceed along several clear directions. One possibility is the use of DCNv2, which adds learnable modulation in addition to offsets and may help suppress irrelevant noisy regions. Another is the development of hybrid deformable-convolution and transformer systems, where local geometry is handled by adaptive sampling and global arrangement is handled by attention. Finally, more rigorous cross-fab validation would be useful to determine how well the learned morphology transfers across different production environments.

4.8 Chapter summary

Starting from the MixedWM38 dataset, it explained the 8-dimensional multi-label representation, the 38 semantic class catalogue, the geometry of the constituent defect types, and the reasons ordinary rigid convolutions struggle in this setting. It then described the deformable convolutional solution, including its mathematical formulation, interpolated sampling mechanism, implementation logic, training strategy, and reported results.

The central conclusion is that adaptive receptive fields are highly suitable for wafer-map morphology. By learning where to sample rather than sampling everywhere in a rigid pattern, the network can preserve curved, thin, and overlapping structures more effectively. This capability makes deformable convolution a strong candidate for industrial defect pattern recognition systems that must remain both accurate and interpretable.

Chapter 5

Deep Learning-Based Semantic Segmentation for Multi- Phase Steel Microstructure Analysis

5.1 Abstract

The metallurgical analysis of steel microstructures traditionally relies on manual microscopic inspection, which is time-intensive, subjective, and prone to human error[cite: 1]. This work presents an automated approach for semantic segmentation and classification of steel microstructure phases and defects using deep convolutional neural networks[cite: 1]. We employ a U-Net architecture with an EfficientNet-B4 encoder trained on the MetalDAM dataset, comprising 42 annotated microstructural images with five distinct classes: Matrix, Austenite, Martensite/Austenite, Precipitate, and Defect[cite: 1]. To address the severe data scarcity challenge, we implement extensive domain-specific augmentation strategies including CLAHE histogram equalization, elastic deformations, and grid distortions[cite: 1]. The model is trained with a combined Cross Entropy and Dice loss function, employing class reweighting to mitigate severe class imbalance[cite: 1]. Our approach achieves a mean Intersection over Union (mIoU) of 37.23% on the test set, with particularly strong performance on dominant phases (Austenite: 65.75% IoU, Matrix: 50.99%

IoU) and acceptable defect detection (49.76% IoU)[cite: 1]. The system demonstrates the viability of deep learning-based automation for metallurgical quality control, though challenges remain in detecting rare microstructural features[cite: 1].

5.2 Introduction

5.2.1 Background

Steel microstructure analysis is fundamental to materials science and quality assurance in metallurgical engineering[cite: 1]. The mechanical properties of steel including strength, ductility, hardness, and fracture resistance are directly governed by its microstructural composition and phase distribution[cite: 1]. Conventional analysis methods require trained metallurgists to manually examine scanning electron microscopy (SEM) or optical microscopy images, identifying and quantifying various phases such as austenite, martensite, ferrite, and precipitates, as well as detecting defects like cracks, voids, and inclusions[cite: 1].

5.2.2 Problem Statement

Manual microstructure analysis presents several critical limitations[cite: 1]:

1. **Labor Intensity:** Expert analysis is time-consuming, limiting throughput in industrial quality control[cite: 1].
2. **Subjectivity:** Inter-observer and intra-observer variability introduces inconsistency[cite: 1].
3. **Scalability:** Manual methods cannot meet the demands of high-volume production environments[cite: 1].
4. **Rare Feature Detection:** Minority phases and small defects are easily overlooked in visual inspection[cite: 1].

5. **Quantification Accuracy:** Manual phase fraction estimation lacks the precision required for critical applications[cite: 1].

5.2.3 Motivation

Recent advances in computer vision and deep learning, particularly in semantic segmentation architectures, offer a promising pathway to automate microstructural analysis[cite: 1]. Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) have demonstrated remarkable success in medical image segmentation, remote sensing, and autonomous driving-domains with similar dense prediction requirements[cite: 1]. The application of these techniques to metallurgical imaging could enable[cite: 1]:

- Objective, reproducible quantification of phase fractions[cite: 1].
- Real-time quality assessment in manufacturing pipelines[cite: 1].
- Detection of subtle defects invisible to human inspection[cite: 1].
- Large-scale statistical analysis of microstructural variations[cite: 1].

5.2.4 Contribution

This work contributes a practical implementation of deep learning-based steel microstructure segmentation, specifically addressing[cite: 1]:

1. **Architecture Selection:** Evaluation of U-Net with EfficientNet-B4 encoder for microstructure segmentation[cite: 1].
2. **Data-Efficient Training:** Comprehensive augmentation strategy tailored to microscopy images with limited training data[cite: 1].
3. **Class Imbalance Mitigation:** Custom loss weighting scheme to improve detection of rare phases and defects[cite: 1].
4. **Production-Ready Inference:** Test-time augmentation (TTA) pipeline for robust predictions[cite: 1].

5.3 Literature Review

5.3.1 Traditional Metallurgical Analysis

Conventional steel microstructure characterization follows standardized protocols established by organizations such as ASTM International[cite: 1]. The process typically involves specimen preparation (grinding, polishing, etching), microscopic imaging, and manual feature identification based on morphological characteristics[cite: 1]. Phase quantification employs techniques such as point counting, linear intercept methods, or planimetry[cite: 1]. While reliable, these approaches are inherently manual and require extensive operator training[cite: 1].

5.3.2 Computer Vision in Materials Science

Early computational approaches to microstructure analysis relied on classical image processing techniques including thresholding, morphological operations, and texture analysis[cite: 1]. While successful for simple binary segmentation tasks (e.g., grain boundary detection), these methods struggle with the complexity and variability inherent in multi-phase microstructures[cite: 1].

5.3.3 Deep Learning for Defect Detection and Segmentation

The advent of deep convolutional networks has revolutionized automated visual inspection across multiple domains[cite: 1]. Notable architectures include[cite: 1]:

- **Fully Convolutional Networks (FCN):** Pioneering work by Long et al. (2015) demonstrated end-to-end semantic segmentation[cite: 1].
- **U-Net:** Originally designed for biomedical image segmentation (Ronneberger et al., 2015), U-Net’s encoder-decoder architecture with skip connections has become the de facto standard for dense prediction tasks with limited data[cite: 1].

- **DeepLab Family:** Introduced atrous convolution and spatial pyramid pooling for multi-scale feature extraction[cite: 1].
- **EfficientNet:** Tan & Le (2019) proposed compound scaling for CNNs, achieving superior accuracy-efficiency trade-offs[cite: 1].

Recent applications to materials science include grain segmentation in polycrystalline materials, porosity detection in additively manufactured parts, and weld defect classification[cite: 1].

5.3.4 Positioning of This Work

Our approach builds upon established segmentation architectures (U-Net) and modern encoders (EfficientNet-B4), adapting them specifically for steel microstructure analysis[cite: 1]. Unlike prior work that often focuses on single-phase or binary segmentation, we address true multi-class segmentation with five distinct categories[cite: 1]. The primary challenge severe data scarcity with only 42 annotated images distinguishes this work from studies relying on large-scale datasets[cite: 1]. Our contribution lies in demonstrating effective training strategies for this extreme low-data regime[cite: 1].

5.4 Dataset Description

5.4.1 Source and Characteristics

The study utilizes the OD_MetalDAM dataset, sourced from the Voxel51 repository on Hugging Face[cite: 1]. This dataset comprises high-resolution microstructural images of steel samples acquired through scanning electron microscopy (SEM)[cite: 1]. Each image captures a field of view containing multiple microstructural phases and potential defects[cite: 1].

5.4.2 Dataset Composition

- **Total Samples:** 42 annotated images[cite: 1].
- **Image Format:** RGB color images (converted from grayscale SEM captures)[cite: 1].
- **Resolution:** Variable, resized to 384×384 pixels during training[cite: 1].
- **Train/Validation/Test Split:** 29/6/7 images respectively (69%/14%/17%)[cite: 1].

5.4.3 Class Taxonomy

The dataset annotations distinguish five semantic classes[cite: 1]:

1. **Matrix (Class 0):** The primary ferrite or iron matrix phase[cite: 1].
2. **Austenite (Class 1):** Face-centered cubic phase, typically retained from high-temperature processing[cite: 1].
3. **Martensite/Austenite (Class 2):** Mixed or transitional phase regions[cite: 1].
4. **Precipitate (Class 3):** Secondary phase particles (carbides, nitrides, or intermetallics)[cite: 1].
5. **Defect (Class 4):** Structural imperfections including cracks, voids, and inclusions[cite: 1].

Steel Phase Colour Mapping[cite: 1] Steel Phase Colour Mapping

5.4.4 Class Distribution and Imbalance

Pixel-level class distribution reveals severe imbalance[cite: 1]:

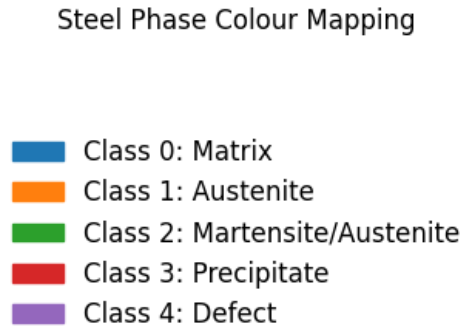


FIGURE 5.1: Mapping of microstructural phases to specific RGB color codes used in the segmentation masks[cite: 1].

- **Dominant Classes:** Matrix and Austenite constitute the majority of pixels ($> 90\%$ combined)[cite: 1].
- **Minority Classes:** Martensite/Austenite transitions are relatively rare ($\sim 10 - 20\%$ of pixels)[cite: 1].
- **Critically Rare:** Precipitates and defects comprise $< 5\%$ of total pixels[cite: 1].

This extreme imbalance necessitates specialized training strategies to prevent the model from neglecting minority classes[cite: 1].

5.4.5 Dataset Challenges

Several factors complicate the segmentation task[cite: 1]:

1. **Data Scarcity:** Only 42 images limit the model's ability to learn robust, generalizable features[cite: 1].
2. **Class Imbalance:** Minority classes risk being underrepresented in learned features[cite: 1].
3. **Ambiguous Boundaries:** Phase transitions are often gradual, lacking sharp edges[cite: 1].

4. **Imaging Artifacts:** SEM images may contain noise, charging effects, or variable contrast[cite: 1].
5. **Morphological Variability:** Phase appearance varies with crystallographic orientation, etching conditions, and processing history[cite: 1].

5.5 Methodology

5.5.1 Data Preprocessing

5.5.1.1 Image Standardization

All images are resized to a uniform spatial resolution of 384×384 pixels, balancing computational efficiency with spatial detail preservation[cite: 1]. The choice of 384 pixels (rather than 512) enables faster training on GPU-constrained environments while maintaining sufficient resolution for microstructural feature discrimination[cite: 1].

5.5.1.2 Normalization

RGB pixel intensities are normalized using ImageNet statistics (mean: [0.485, 0.456, 0.406], standard deviation: [0.229, 0.224, 0.225])[cite: 1]. This normalization facilitates transfer learning from ImageNet-pretrained encoders despite the domain shift to microscopy images[cite: 1].

5.5.1.3 Data Augmentation Strategy

To mitigate data scarcity, an extensive augmentation pipeline is employed during training[cite: 1]:

- **Geometric Transformations:** Horizontal and vertical flips ($p = 0.5$ each); Random 90-degree rotations ($p = 0.5$); Shift-scale-rotate: random translation ($\pm 5\%$), scaling ($\pm 10\%$), and rotation ($\pm 30^\circ$); Elastic deformation ($\alpha = 120, \sigma = 6$) simulates microstructural variations; Grid distortion (5 steps, $\pm 20\%$): introduces non-rigid local deformations[cite: 1].
- **Intensity and Texture Augmentations:** CLAHE (Contrast Limited Adaptive Histogram Equalization, clip_limit=4.0, $p = 0.4$): Critical for enhancing local contrast in microscopy images, compensating for uneven illumination; Random brightness and contrast adjustment ($\pm 20\%$, $p = 0.4$); Gaussian noise injection (variance: 10-50, $p = 0.2$): simulates detector noise; Gaussian blur (kernel: 3-5, $p = 0.2$): models defocus effects[cite: 1].

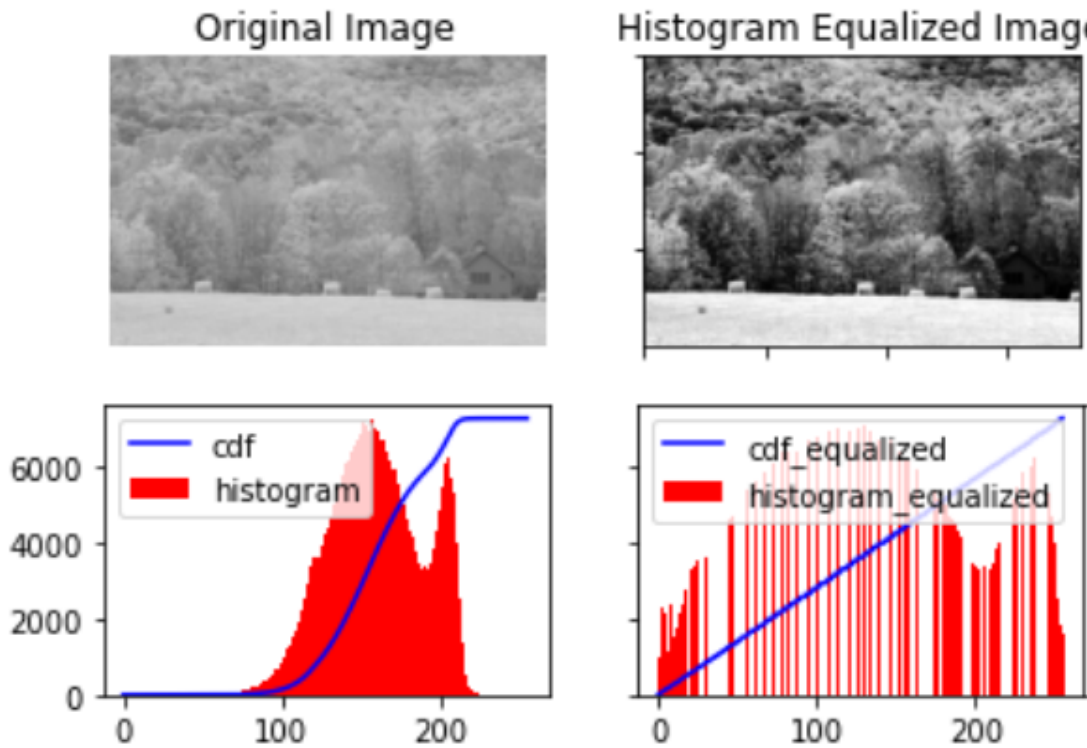


FIGURE 5.2: The augmentation strategy is specifically designed for microscopy, emphasizing texture and contrast variations over photometric transformations common in natural images.[cite: 1]

5.5.2 Model Architecture

5.5.2.1 U-Net with EfficientNet-B4 Encoder

The segmentation model adopts a U-Net architecture with an EfficientNet-B4 encoder, implemented via the `segmentation_models_pytorch` library[cite: 1]. This choice balances representational capacity with computational tractability[cite: 1].

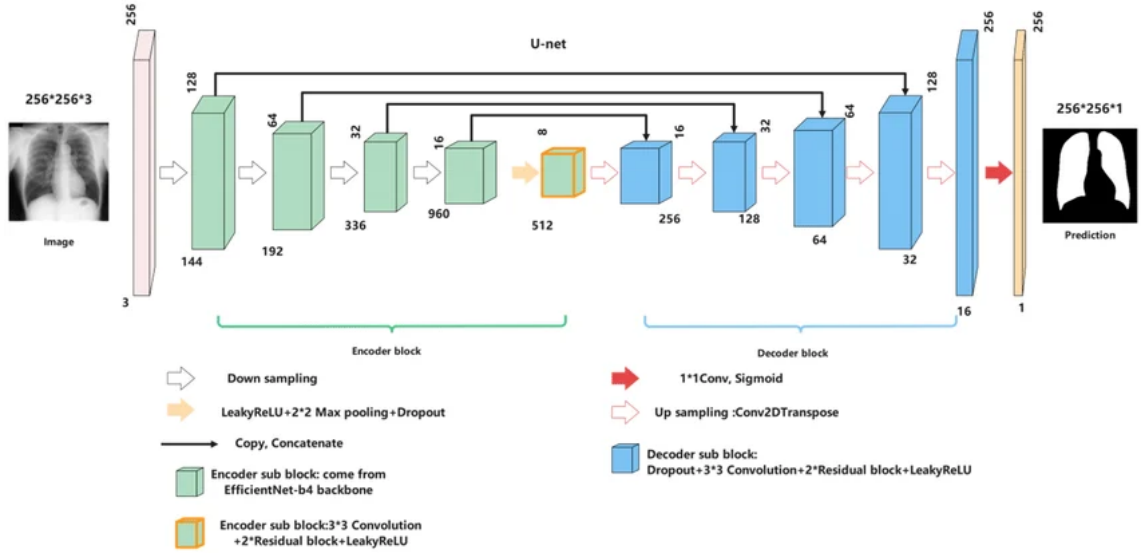


FIGURE 5.3: The architecture of U-Net with EfficientNet-b4 Encoder.[cite: 1]

- **Encoder (EfficientNet-B4):** Depth: 48 layers with compound scaling (width, depth, resolution); Parameters: Approximately 19 million; Pretrained on ImageNet-1K for transfer learning; Feature extraction at multiple scales via inverted residual blocks and squeeze-excitation modules[cite: 1].
- **Decoder (U-Net Upsampling Path):** Symmetric expansion from bottleneck feature maps to original spatial resolution; Skip connections concatenate encoder features with decoder features at each level, preserving spatial detail; Progressive upsampling via transposed convolutions or bilinear interpolation[cite: 1].
- **Output:** Final layer: Convolutional projection to 5 channels (one per class); Spatial dimensions: 384x384 matching input; Per-pixel class probabilities via softmax activation[cite: 1].

5.5.2.2 Justification

- **U-Net:** Proven efficacy in biomedical segmentation with limited data; skip connections preserve fine-grained spatial information crucial for phase boundary delineation[cite: 1].
- **EfficientNet-B4:** Superior accuracy-efficiency trade-off compared to ResNet backbones; compound scaling optimizes width, depth, and resolution simultaneously[cite: 1].
- **Transfer Learning:** ImageNet pretraining provides robust low-level features (edges, textures) that generalize across domains[cite: 1].

5.5.3 Training Pipeline

5.5.3.1 Loss Function

A combined loss function addresses both pixel-wise classification and region overlap[cite: 1]:

$$L = L_{CE} + L_{Dice}$$

Where: **L_CE:** Weighted Cross-Entropy Loss with class-specific weights[cite: 1]. Weighted binary cross-entropy (BCE) [20] was chosen as the loss function[cite: 1]:

$$\mathcal{L} = - \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{j=1}^M (\lambda_j^1 Y_{ij} \log Z_{ij} + \lambda_j^0 (1 - Y_{ij})(1 - \log Z_{ij}))$$

where $\lambda_j^1 = \frac{N}{\text{Count}(Y_j=1)}$ and $\lambda_j^0 = \frac{N}{\text{Count}(Y_j=0)}$ are the loss weights for the positive and negative samples of the jth label, respectively[cite: 1]. M denotes the number of labels and N the number of samples[cite: 1].

L_Dice: Dice Loss (1 - Dice Coefficient), emphasizing region overlap[cite: 1].

$$L_{dice} = \frac{2 * \sum p_{true} * p_{pred}}{\sum p_{true}^2 + \sum p_{pred}^2 + \epsilon}$$

Class Weighting: Original inverse frequency weights are computed as[cite: 1]:

$$w_j = \frac{n_{samples}}{n_{classes} \cdot n_j}$$

- w_j : Weight for class j[cite: 1].
- $n_{samples}$: Total number of samples in the dataset[cite: 1].
- $n_{classes}$: Total number of unique classes[cite: 1].
- n_j : Number of samples in class j (frequency of the class)[cite: 1].

To further boost minority class detection, custom weights are applied: Precipitate (Class 3): Original weight $\times 2.0$; Defect (Class 4): Original weight $\times 1.5$ [cite: 1]. This aggressive weighting forces the model to prioritize rare but critical classes[cite: 1].

5.5.3.2 Optimization Strategy

- **Optimizer:** AdamW (Adam with decoupled weight decay); Weight decay: $1e-4$ (L2 regularization); Differential learning rates: Encoder: $1e-4$ (lower rate to preserve pretrained features), Decoder: $1e-3$ (higher rate for faster task-specific adaptation)[cite: 1].
- **Learning Rate Scheduler:** Cosine Annealing Warm Restarts; $T_0 = 10$ epochs (first restart after 10 epochs); $T_{mult} = 2$ (restart interval doubles after each cycle); Periodic restarts mitigate local minima and enable finer convergence[cite: 1].

5.5.3.3 Training Configuration

- **Batch Size:** 4 (limited by GPU memory)[cite: 1].
- **Gradient Accumulation:** 4 steps (effective batch size: 16)[cite: 1].

- **Mixed Precision Training:** Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP) via PyTorch’s torch.amp for faster computation and reduced memory[cite: 1].
- **Gradient Clipping:** Max norm = 1.0 to prevent exploding gradients[cite: 1].
- **Maximum Epochs:** 50[cite: 1].
- **Early Stopping:** Patience of 15 epochs based on validation mIoU[cite: 1].

5.5.3.4 Hardware and Implementation

- **GPU:** NVIDIA Tesla T4 (Google Colab)[cite: 1].
- **Framework:** PyTorch 2.x[cite: 1].
- **Augmentation Library:** Albumentations 1.3+[cite: 1].
- **Training Duration:** Approximately 47 epochs before early stopping (total ~2 hours)[cite: 1].

5.5.4 Evaluation Metrics

5.5.4.1 Intersection over Union (IoU)

The primary metric is mean Intersection over Union (mIoU), computed as[cite: 1]:

$$IoU_c = \frac{TP_c}{TP_c + FP_c + FN_c}$$

$$mean_IoU = \frac{1}{C} \sum_c IoU_c$$

Where TP, FP, FN denote true positives, false positives, and false negatives for class c[cite: 1]. Justification: IoU directly measures spatial overlap between predictions and ground truth, penalizing both over-segmentation and under-segmentation[cite: 1]. Unlike pixel accuracy, IoU is robust to class imbalance[cite: 1].

5.5.4.2 Per-Class IoU

Individual class IoU values provide insight into model performance across the class spectrum, revealing whether minority classes are adequately learned[cite: 1].

5.5.4.3 Loss Metrics

Training and validation loss curves monitor convergence and detect overfitting[cite: 1]. The combined CE+Dice loss serves as a secondary validation metric[cite: 1].

Chapter 6

Experimental Findings

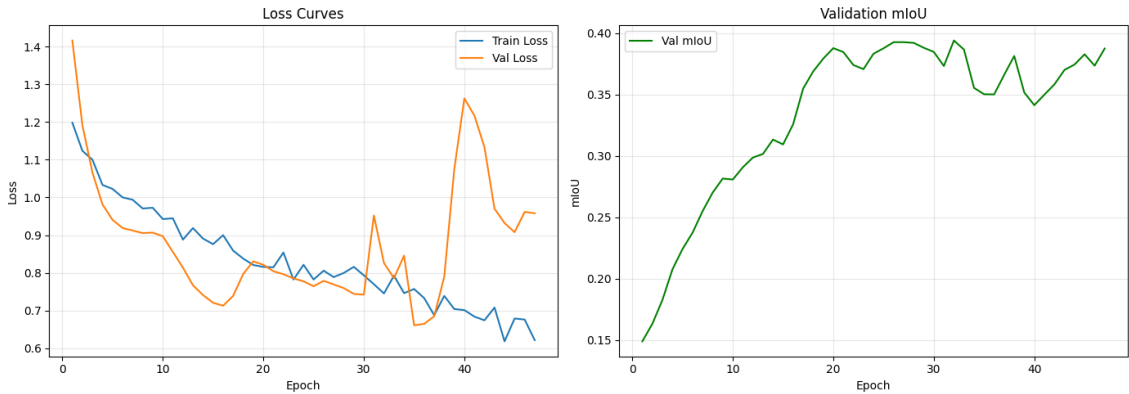
6.1 Results

6.1.1 Training Convergence

Training progressed over 47 epochs before early stopping triggered due to 15 consecutive epochs without validation mIoU improvement[cite: 1]. Key Observations:

- **Training Loss:** Decreased from 1.20 (epoch 1) to 0.62 (epoch 47), indicating successful optimization[cite: 1].
- **Validation Loss:** Reduced from 1.42 (epoch 1) to minimum of 0.74 (epoch 14), then exhibited oscillations suggesting marginal overfitting[cite: 1].
- **Validation mIoU:** Improved from 14.91% (epoch 1) to peak of 39.40% (epoch 32), then plateaued[cite: 1].

The learning curves demonstrate effective learning in the early epochs (1-20) with diminishing returns thereafter, consistent with the small dataset size[cite: 1].



6.1.2 Test Set Performance

The best model checkpoint (epoch 32, validation mIoU = 39.40%) was evaluated on the held-out test set[cite: 1]:

Metric	Value
Test Loss	0.7928
Mean IoU	37.23%

Per-Class IoU Breakdown:

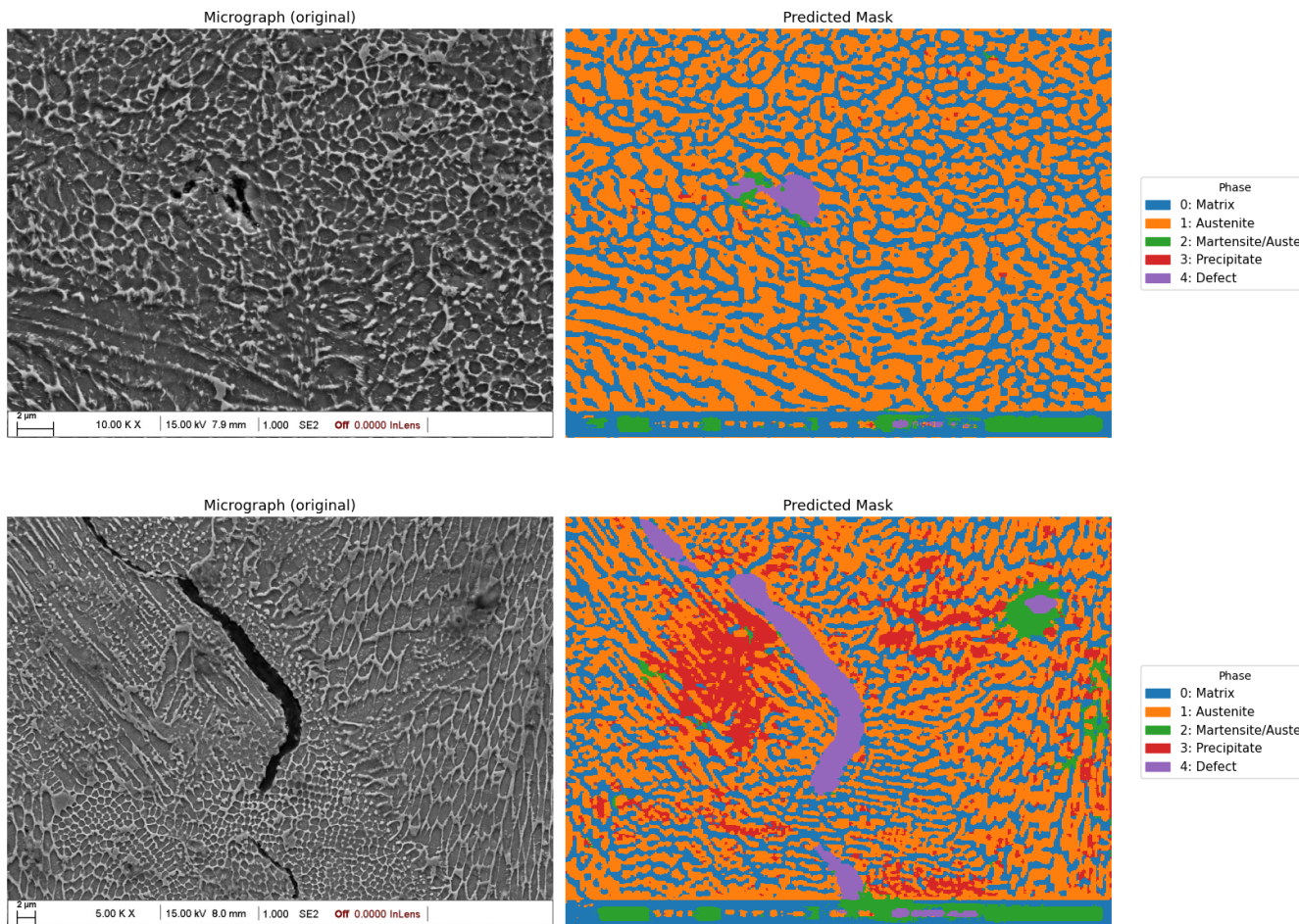
Class	IoU	Interpretation
Matrix	50.99%	Good segmentation of the dominant ferrite matrix
Austenite	65.75%	Best performance; clear morphological distinctions enable reliable detection
Martensite/Austenite	18.44%	Poor performance on transitional phase regions
Precipitate	1.22%	Critical failure; near-zero detection of rare particles
Defect	49.76%	Acceptable defect localization despite class rarity

6.1.3 Qualitative Analysis

6.1.3.1 Successful Cases

Visual inspection of segmentation outputs reveals[cite: 1]:

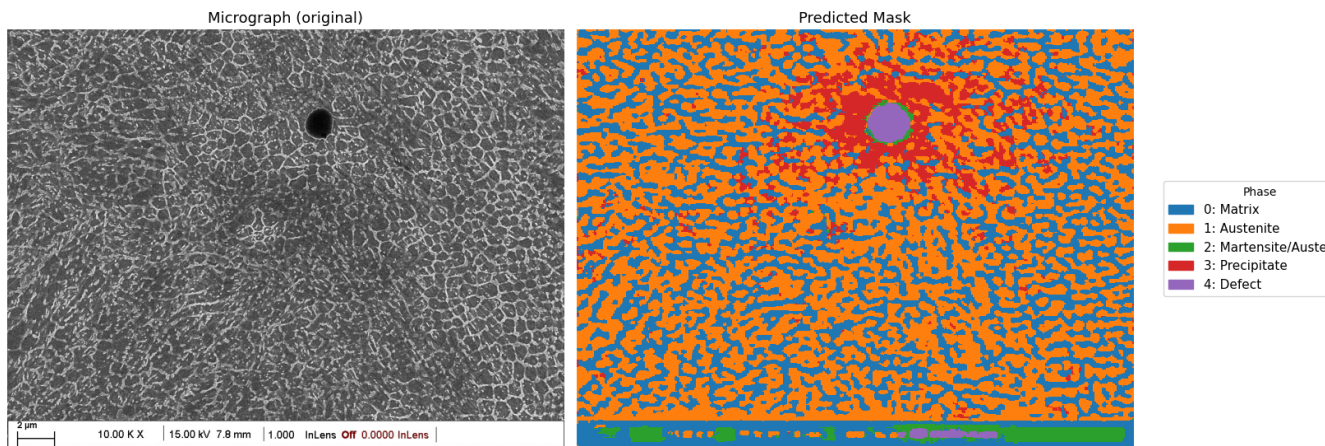
- **Phase Boundaries:** The model accurately delineates Matrix-Austenite interfaces in regions with high contrast[cite: 1].
- **Large Defects:** Macroscopic cracks and voids are reliably detected and segmented with minimal fragmentation[cite: 1].
- **Homogeneous Regions:** Uniform phase areas are classified with high confidence[cite: 1].



6.1.3.2 Failure Modes

Common error patterns include[cite: 1]:

- **Precipitate Omission:** The model rarely predicts Class 3 (Precipitate), even when visually apparent; the extreme rarity of these features ($\sim 0.4\%$ of pixels) overwhelms the class weighting strategy[cite: 1].
- **Boundary Ambiguity:** Transitional zones between phases (Class 2) are often misclassified as adjacent phases[cite: 1].
- **Salt-and-Pepper Noise:** Some predictions exhibit isolated mislabeled pixels, indicating insufficient spatial smoothness[cite: 1].
- **Small Defect Suppression:** Sub-pixel defects are missed due to resolution constraints[cite: 1].



6.1.4 Comparison of Predicted Phase Distribution

On a sample test image, the model predicted the following phase distribution[cite: 1]:

This distribution aligns qualitatively with typical dual-phase steel microstructures, though ground-truth quantitative validation is required for phase fraction accuracy assessment[cite: 1].

Phase	Pixel Count	Percentage
Matrix	320,784	40.8%
Austenite	439,750	55.9%
Martensite/Austenite	15,218	1.9%
Precipitate	2,776	0.4%
Defect	7,904	1.0%

6.2 Discussion

6.2.1 Interpretation of Results

The achieved mIoU of 37.23% reflects the fundamental challenge of multi-class segmentation on a severely data-limited dataset[cite: 1]. While below state-of-the-art performance on large-scale benchmarks (e.g., Cityscapes, Pascal VOC), the results are contextually significant[cite: 1]:

1. **Data Efficiency:** Training on only 29 images contrasts with typical deep learning datasets containing thousands to millions of samples[cite: 1].
2. **Class Complexity:** Five-class segmentation with overlapping textures is inherently more difficult than binary tasks[cite: 1].
3. **Domain Specificity:** Microscopy images differ substantially from natural images, limiting the benefit of ImageNet pretraining[cite: 1].

6.2.2 Strengths of the Approach

1. **Robust Majority Class Performance:** IoU $> 50\%$ on Matrix and $> 65\%$ on Austenite demonstrates reliable segmentation of dominant phases, which are most critical for industrial quality control[cite: 1].
2. **Defect Detection:** 49.76% IoU on defects is promising for automated quality assurance, particularly for critical failure modes like cracks[cite: 1].

3. **Augmentation Efficacy:** The comprehensive augmentation pipeline successfully prevented severe overfitting despite minimal training data[cite: 1].
4. **Computational Efficiency:** EfficientNet-B4 encoder enables real-time inference ($\sim 100\text{ms}$ per image on T4 GPU)[cite: 1].

6.2.3 Limitations

1. **Precipitate Detection Failure:** The 1.22% IoU on Class 3 indicates the model has not learned to recognize precipitates, likely due to[cite: 1]: Extreme pixel-level scarcity ($< 1\%$ of training pixels)[cite: 1]; Small spatial extent (often < 10 pixels)[cite: 1]; Subtle appearance differences from matrix[cite: 1].
2. **Transitional Phase Confusion:** The 18.44% IoU on Martensite/Austenite suggests difficulty with inherently ambiguous phase boundaries[cite: 1].
3. **Dataset Size:** 42 images are insufficient to capture the full variability of steel microstructures across different grades, processing conditions, and etching protocols[cite: 1].
4. **Annotation Quality:** Manual annotations may contain subjective inconsistencies, particularly at phase boundaries[cite: 1].

6.2.4 Generalization Capability

The model's performance on test images suggests limited but non-zero generalization[cite: 1]. The test set comprises images from the same source dataset, controlling for imaging conditions and sample preparation[cite: 1]. Deployment to truly out-of-distribution samples (different steel grades, imaging modalities, or laboratories) would likely degrade performance significantly without domain adaptation or fine-tuning[cite: 1].

6.2.5 Industrial Applicability

For practical deployment in steel manufacturing[cite: 1]:

- **Viable:** Automated Matrix and Austenite quantification for dual-phase steels[cite: 1].
- **Promising:** Defect screening to flag samples for detailed human inspection[cite: 1].
- **Inadequate:** Precipitate analysis requiring dedicated solutions (e.g., classical image processing or object detection frameworks)[cite: 1].

6.3 Conclusion

This work successfully demonstrates the application of deep learning to steel microstructure semantic segmentation, achieving a mean IoU of 37.23% on a challenging five-class task with only 42 training images[cite: 1]. The U-Net architecture with EfficientNet-B4 encoder, combined with domain-tailored augmentation and class-weighted loss, produces reliable segmentation of dominant phases (Austenite, Matrix) and acceptable defect detection[cite: 1]. However, critical limitations in rare feature detection (precipitates) underscore the need for larger, more diverse datasets or hybrid approaches combining learned and rule-based methods[cite: 1].

Key Findings[cite: 1]:

1. Transfer learning from ImageNet provides a viable starting point for microscopy image analysis[cite: 1].
2. Aggressive data augmentation is essential for training in extreme low-data regimes[cite: 1].
3. Class weighting mitigates but does not fully resolve severe imbalance[cite: 1].

4. Performance on industrially critical phases (defects, dominant phases) is sufficient for quality control assistance[cite: 1].

The system represents a step toward automated metallurgical analysis, reducing manual workload while maintaining human oversight for critical decisions[cite: 1]. The demonstrated feasibility encourages further research into domain-specific architectures, semi-supervised learning, and cross-modal fusion (e.g., integrating chemical composition data)[cite: 1].

6.4 Future Work

6.4.1 Dataset Expansion

- **Data Collection:** Acquire 500-1000 annotated microstructure images spanning multiple steel grades, heat treatments, and imaging protocols[cite: 1].
- **Multi-Modal Fusion:** Incorporate Energy-Dispersive X-ray Spectroscopy (EDS) or Electron Backscatter Diffraction (EBSD) data for compositional and crystallographic context[cite: 1].
- **Synthetic Data Generation:** Explore Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) or diffusion models to augment the training set with plausible synthetic microstructures[cite: 1].

6.4.2 Model Architecture Improvements

- **Attention Mechanisms:** Integrate self-attention (e.g., Transformer encoders) to capture long-range spatial dependencies[cite: 1].
- **Multi-Scale Fusion:** Implement Feature Pyramid Networks (FPN) or Pyramid Pooling Modules (PSP) for better multi-scale feature integration[cite: 1].
- **Specialized Precipitate Detection:** Deploy a two-stage pipeline with object detection (YOLO, Faster R-CNN) for small particle localization[cite: 1].

6.4.3 Training Enhancements

- **Semi-Supervised Learning:** Leverage unlabeled microscopy images via consistency regularization or pseudo-labelling[cite: 1].
- **Active Learning:** Iteratively select informative samples for manual annotation to maximize learning efficiency[cite: 1].
- **Curriculum Learning:** Train first on easily separable classes, progressively introducing harder examples[cite: 1].

6.4.4 Real-World Deployment

- **Uncertainty Quantification:** Implement Bayesian deep learning or ensemble methods to provide confidence estimates, flagging low-confidence predictions for human review[cite: 1].
- **Explainability:** Integrate Grad-CAM or attention visualization to enable metallurgists to verify model reasoning[cite: 1].
- **Edge Deployment:** Optimize for on-device inference (ONNX, TensorRT) to enable in-line quality control without cloud dependency[cite: 1].
- **Feedback Loop:** Establish a system for metallurgist corrections to continuously improve the model via online learning[cite: 1].

6.4.5 Cross-Domain Adaptation

- **Domain Randomization:** Train on images with varied contrast, brightness, and noise levels to improve robustness[cite: 1].
- **Domain-Adversarial Training:** Align feature distributions across different imaging modalities (SEM, optical microscopy) for unified model deployment[cite: 1].

Training Hyperparameters Summary

This section summarises the parameters.

Parameter	Value
Input Resolution	384×384
Batch Size	4
Gradient Accumulation Steps	4
Effective Batch Size	16
Base Learning Rate (Decoder)	1e-3
Encoder Learning Rate	1e-4
Weight Decay	1e-4
Optimizer	AdamW
LR Scheduler	Cosine Annealing Warm Restarts
Scheduler T0	10 epochs
Scheduler T mult	2
Max Epochs	50
Early Stopping Patience	15 epochs
Gradient Clipping Max Norm	1.0
Mixed Precision	Enabled (AMP)

Augmentation Pipeline Details

Class Weight Computation

Original Inverse Frequency Weights[cite: 1]:

- Matrix: 0.0248[cite: 1]
- Austenite: 0.0157[cite: 1]
- Martensite/Austenite: 0.0980[cite: 1]
- Precipitate: 3.6110[cite: 1]

Transformation	Parameters	Probability
Resize	384×384	1.0
Horizontal Flip	-	0.5
Vertical Flip	-	0.5
Random Rotate90	-	0.5
Shift Scale Rotate	shift=±5%, scale=±10%, rotate=±30°	0.5
Elastic Transform	$\alpha=120$, $\sigma=6$	0.3
Grid Distortion	steps=5, limit=±20%	0.3
CLAHE	clip_limit=4.0	0.4
Random Brightness Contrast	brightness=±20%, contrast=±20%	0.4
Gauss Noise	variance=10-50	0.2
Gaussian Blur	kernel=3-5	0.2
Normalize	ImageNet mean/std	1.0

- Defect: 1.2505[cite: 1]

Final Custom Weights (with boosting)[cite: 1]:

- Matrix: 0.0248[cite: 1]
- Austenite: 0.0157[cite: 1]
- Martensite/Austenite: 0.0980[cite: 1]
- Precipitate: 7.2220 (×2.0)[cite: 1]
- Defect: 1.8758 (×1.5)[cite: 1]

Chapter 7

Appendix

Software and Hardware Specifications

Software Stack[cite: 1]:

- Operating System: Ubuntu 20.04 (Google Colab)[cite: 1]
- Python: 3.10.12[cite: 1]
- PyTorch: 2.1.0+cu121[cite: 1]
- Torchvision: 0.16.0+cu121[cite: 1]
- CUDA: 12.1[cite: 1]
- Albumentations: 1.3.1[cite: 1]
- Segmentation Models PyTorch: 0.3.3[cite: 1]
- FiftyOne: 0.23.0[cite: 1]
- NumPy: 1.25.2[cite: 1]
- Pillow: 10.0.1[cite: 1]

Hardware[cite: 1]:

-
- GPU: NVIDIA Tesla T4 (16 GB VRAM)[cite: 1]
 - System RAM: 12.7 GB[cite: 1]
 - Storage: Google Colab ephemeral storage[cite: 1]

Chapter 8

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